

Outer Lands

The Outer Lands

No one who lives there calls it the Outer Lands.

The name comes from elsewhere. It is spoken in Rider's Council chambers, murmured by Settlan merchants counting risk, written in Fatunik chronicles where uncertainty is treated as a defect. Outer is a word of convenience. It means difficult to classify. It means resistant to tidy governance. It means a place where the usual rules fray, where institutions fail to reproduce themselves cleanly, and where explanations arrive late or not at all.

The Outer Lands sit east and south of the great settled powers. The United Rider Provinces are remote, far to the west. The Fatunik Dominion is right next door, to the north and west. But geography alone does not make them strange. What marks them as "outer" is how they behave under pressure. Where other regions harden into certainty, the Outer Lands flex. Where laws calcify elsewhere, here they argue, adapt, or quietly stop applying. This has not made the region peaceful. It has made it volatile, alive with friction, prone to sudden shifts that ripple outward like cracks in winter ice that send their sound waves peeling across many kilometers.

The Weight of Air and Earth

Approach from any direction and you feel it before you see it. The quality of the light changes when you enter the provinces of the Outer Lands. The air tastes different. Sometimes it is salt and smoke. Sometimes of wet stone. Sometimes turned earth as far as the eye can see. Storm clouds mass and dissipate according to patterns that defy

the old predictions. Rivers re-route themselves mid-season, carving new channels through land that was dry the year before.

Crop failures come often, but not everywhere at once. The Outer Lands are too fractured for that. But somewhere, always. Fields that should yield go barren. Harvests rot in the ground or wither before they can be gathered. Ancient waterworks groan under pressures they were never designed to carry. Dams hold, then they don't. Bridges last a century, then their foundations give way, collapsing in a single night of ordinary rain.

People do not live here because it is safe. They live here because, for reasons of faith, exile, stubbornness, history, or unfinished business, they cannot imagine living anywhere else.

The soil is rich in places. It is volcanic dark in many parts of Mobalbesq. Deep and fertile near the Great Lake of Bye and the rich river valleys surrounding it. But richness means little when the rain refuses to fall, or when it falls so hard the earth cannot drink it fast enough. Every season is a negotiation. Every harvest, a reprieve.

Three Provinces Bound by Refusal

Outsiders speak of the Outer Lands as a single place, a uniform frontier where the normal order of things, as understood by Fatunik loyalists at any rate, breaks down. In truth, they are three very distinct provinces bound together not some much by shared borders as by a habit of negotiation and a shared refusal to become simple. Or predictable.

The Runes of Bye spread out in every direction from the shores of the Great Lake of Bye.

It is a province of argument, process, and long memories. Along with the monumental carvings that dot the countryside, fragments of stone runes older than hum settlement show us everywhere. Half-incorporated into wall, causeways, road markers and foundation

stones. Their original purpose is debated endlessly but never fully agreed upon. In Byenung town the Night Hall holds court and keeps records and indexes memories. It is a place where decisions accrete like sediment rather than arriving as decrees, where disagreement is method, not weakness. The Runik folk argue with the world and with themselves, insisting that truth emerges from collision rather than consensus. Their engineering wonders are acclaimed throughout the Saskan Lands. The damming of the Settan River which led to the astonishing expansion of the Great Lake most of all. The inland sea created by hum engineering in the Runes of Bye stands as irrefutable proof that stubbornness, properly applied, can, if nothing else, move unbelievably massive quantities of water and stone.

And the never-ending wrangling by Night Hall scholars proves that nothing, not even something as memorable as the enlargement of the Great Lake of Bye, is ever truly settled.

Mobalbesq burns.

The Communes of Fire govern themselves face to face, loudly, and from time to time with kicks and fists. Fatunik fire cults dominate the spiritual landscape here, teaching that Fatune's will is expressed through the decisions of sentient beings and that destruction and renewal cannot be separated cleanly into some cosmic story. Fatune's cycles are an everyday affair that require close attention. Fields are burned to save them. Old buildings are razed to make room for something uncertain but necessary. Authority must be visible, accountable and present, or it is meaningless. The two big fortified towns of Mobalbesq, Selaron on the coast and Morilly inland, serve as pressure valves where the province interfaces with the wider world. Ships come and go, sometimes under flags no one recognizes. Deals are struck that will not be written down because permanence is an illusion.

And at the heart of it all, in the sprawling and time-worn Moballeq Compound, the Mother of Fires, Monmar Massachawa watches and prepares, refusing to explain herself any longer to the powers that

stopped listening to her long ago.

The Ny Lands move.

Their people are traders, warriors, road-keepers, and treaty-holders. Authority here is inherited, challenged, and reaffirmed through deeds, songs and partnerships. The Nylanders know the roads better than anyone, including where those roads no longer behave as expected, where the ground vibrates strangely at night, where movements of the wild animals have shifted in ways that suggest the land itself is paying attention. They enforce passage through unwritten contracts. You hire them, or you cross without permission and accept the consequences. Each year they host the Feast at Wildwind, the original version. The Feast at Wildwind is nothing like the Selaron Fair. It is not a sober affair, but its renown nearly equals that of the great annual market fair in Mobalbesq.

The Feast at Wildwind is a gathering where shared rituals briefly make Nyland unity visible so that all the tribes can remember who they are again before returning to their separate paths.

What Keeps the Collapse at Bay

The Outer Lands should not work.

They share no common authority. Their economies depend on routes that fail unpredictably, harvests that cannot be guaranteed, contracts that are not written down and arguments that never end. Rider Arms patrol the major roads through the region, but their mandate is narrower here, more negotiated, especially in the Ny Lands. Local Fatunik Volunteers build clinics and granaries, preaching a faith that promises order through shared obligation, but their influence waxes and wanes with the weather. These are not the Volunteers of Tonedor Rumpet. They follow the old ways, working as mutual aid teams and militias if needed in times of trouble. Some also belong to the Mobali fire cults, participate in research projects sponsored by the Night Hall,

or ride with Nylander patrols.

Tagabant soldiers and Watchers sent from Beshquahoek keep close tabs on the Outer Lands but intervene rarely. When they do cross the boundaries, they do it decisively when it means maintaining the dignity and authority of the Khālo Bridge (the Tagabant banner) or of the Eye of the Candle (the Grand Tagabant) matters more than worrying about the reaction of folks who are, after all, Fatunik in name only.

What prevents total collapse is not unity, but friction.

Interminable debates in the Night Hall keep disagreements procedural rather than violent. Most of the time. Fires in the Communes force decisions to be made in the open, where cowardice is easily called out. Treaties enforced by the Nylanders create just enough predictability for trade to survive, even when trust does not. Each system checks the others, imperfectly, often too late, but persistently enough that the whole creaking structure stays upright. In this strange way, like how lopsided buildings in Brokily town keep each other standing against all odds, the three provinces of the Outer Lands fill in each others' gaps and keep each other steady.

A visitor from Terpinol once described the Outer Lands as "a dozen catastrophes on the verge of happening, somehow holding one another back through mutual irritation." The Magisters of Byenung considered this for several hours, then filed it away as "reasonably accurate, if incomplete," along with thousands of other notes and annotation collected over the centuries in a chamber of the Library devoted exclusively to the topic of "Suggestions and Considerations for Improvements to Functional and Methodological Procedures".

Strangers Among Us

Walk through any market in Selaron or Byenung and you will see the full range of what the hum have become in the centuries since the

Great Catastrophe. Here the hum, which is to say pure human stock, mingle with mixed-heritage folk whose mixt bloodlines carry adaptations no one fully understands. Animal sints move through the crowds too. Rabbit-sint workers coordinating logistics with twitching ears and quick hands. Dripping-wet otter-bodied couriers who know the rivers as well as the roads. Lizard-formed merchants whose memories are long and whose grudges are longer.

The Outer Lands are more tolerant of this variety than some regions, less so than others. What matters here is not form but function. Can you do the work? Will you remember and honor the contract right up until its expiry date? Can you listen to someone else's explanation long enough to be taken seriously when it is your turn to speak?

Jaxen, those shallow-affect hum-appearing creatures whose emotional range runs narrow and cold, do poorly here but are not treated badly. They pass by the lax border inspections easily enough. What unmakes them is the depth of engagement required. A Jaxen can recite a contract but cannot navigate the negotiation that precedes it. They can even attend a Night Hall session, sometimes repeating the key points, but cannot improvise when the argument shifts. They can stand in a Commune assembly but cannot read the room when silence is widely understood to mean "OK, so we can act now."

Explanation invites debate, and debate requires the very capacity Jaxen lack. Most are identified without accusation and simply left to do the menial tasks that they seem to desire.

What the Future Holds (Or Refuses to Hold)

The Outer Lands are not a refuge from crisis. They are where crises accumulate and then get resolved.

Rain fails, then returns all at once. Roads wash out. Engineering works fail under loads they once carried easily. Old faiths and old routines fracture along new fault lines. Rumors move faster than

caravans, and some of them turn out to be true. A storm arrived without clouds. Lights were seen deep beneath the Great Lake. Ny Land guards suddenly refuse access to certain roads without any explanation.

The big powers, the Riders and the Dominion, tend to want the region to stabilize. They would like to see clear borders, reliable markets and predictable behaviors. They want the Outer Lands to make sense in the way provinces are supposed to make sense, with hierarchies that cascade downward and laws that stay put. What they find instead is a place where the future is very much in the making, has not yet been decided. Where every attempt to impose finality carries real cost, can lead to a lost deal, for example, despite the fact that things seem to move faster in the Outer Lands than in other regions. Where memory is really kept in people and buildings rather than monuments, despite the region hosting many more ancient monuments than any other. It makes it not only very difficult to strategize how to control such a place, but even harder to erase its influence on Saskan folk everywhere.

Outsiders see disorder and sometimes a threat.

Those who live there see a place still deciding what it wants to become and what it needs to do. A place where catastrophe might yet be avoided not through obedience or force, but through the grinding, exhausting work of actually paying attention to the consequences of every action.

That uncertainty is why the Outer Lands endure.

It is also why they unsettle those who want the world to behave in a certain way.

The wind shifts over the Great Lake of Bye. In Mobalbesq, ritual fires are banked for the night. On the roads through the Ny Lands, guards change watch without speaking, listening to sounds that have no names. And in the Night Hall, deliberations continue in lamplight that

never quite goes out, because someone must remember that the world does not owe us answers, only the chance to ask better questions before the ground shifts yet again.

Fatune Settles Down

The field should have yielded.

Every calculation said so. The soil was right, tested and retested by methods refined over generations. The planting calendar matched patterns that had worked for sixty turns. Rain came when it was supposed to come. The seeds were from stock that had never failed. And yet when harvest time arrived, the stalks stood withered, grain heads empty, the whole crop lost to something no one could name.

In the Fatunik Dominion's western provinces, the response would be immediate and theological. Inspectors would arrive to investigate what sin had been committed, what ritual had been performed incorrectly, what deviation from approved practice had caused Fatune to withdraw favor. Someone would be blamed. Correction would be imposed. The community would be taught, again, that obedience to Fatune prevents catastrophe.

In Mobalbesq, the Runes of Bye and the Ny Lands the response is different. The commune or the village or the tribe gathers. They examine the field, the soil, the records. They compare this failure to others, looking for patterns. An elder, perhaps a devout Fire Temple elder, or a longtime Fatunik volunteer, points out that three other fields failed the same way, all on south-facing slopes, all planted within the same week. An engineer notes that the irrigation channels in those fields were recently rebuilt using a new design. The group debates whether the design itself was flawed or whether the timing of the rebuild disrupted something in the soil. No one is blamed. No one speaks of sin. By the end of the meeting, they have decided to return

to the old channel design for next season and to delay planting on south slopes by two weeks. If a body can be spared and the learning is important enough, an emissary may be sent to the Night Hall to report their findings.

Both the Dominion communities and many of those in the so-called Outer Lands believe Fatune matters. Both take the crop failure seriously. But one treats it as punishment requiring submission, and the other treats it as information requiring adjustment.

That differences are not theological. They are institutional. And this determines everything about how governance works, or fails to work, across the Saskan Lands.

When Ingar Still Asked Questions

In the earliest period after the Great Catastrophe, when hum populations were scattered and struggling, the settlement of Ingar became the first center of what would later be called Fatunik practice. But practice back then meant something closer to agricultural science mixed with moral philosophy. Fatune fed crops and burned careless skin. It did both without explanation. The question was not whether to obey Fatune but how to learn from it.

Early commentaries from Ingar read more like farming manuals than scripture. A document called the *First Observations*, still kept in the Night Hall Library, contains entries like: "Grain planted three days after at least two full moon yields better in years when spring comes late. Reason unknown. Test again next season." Another section reads: "Children born during summer heat sicken more often in first winter. Consider encouraging births in autumn. Query whether this is true on the coast as well, or only in Ingar's environs."

Ritual existed, but it served coordination more than devotion. Lighting fires at specific times helped communities to synchronize planting. Shared meals after harvest reinforced bonds that would matter when the next crisis came. Debates about proper practice were common and encouraged, not as challenges to authority but as

attempts to refine understanding.

This period produced institutional habits that created deep roots in the Runes of Bye. The assumption that observation matters more than tradition. The belief that disagreement improves conclusions. The practice of writing things down so future generations can check your work and tell you where you were wrong.

It did not last in the territories that came to be known as the Fatunik Dominion.

The Turn Toward Certainty

When doctrinal authority shifted westward to Juuj, the tone changed gradually, over many centuries, then suddenly when crises began to multiply.

The Elders of Juuj were formidable thinkers, genuinely so. For centuries they maintained the older pattern, debating interpretations beside their underground pool, water reflecting lamplight onto faces lined with intelligence and doubt. Their influence spread not through force but through the quality of their reasoning and the beauty of their proclamations. Communities across the Saskan Lands looked to Juuj for guidance because Juuj's guidance was usually sound.

But history began to press. Crop failures multiplied in ways that did not match old patterns. Wars with animal-sint populations who refused integration dragged on longer and caused more suffering than anyone had expected. The Kahila rejectionists, not in faraway Arq or Baranuk, not animal-sints, but hum living right next to Juukal province in the Kahila Forest, proved impossible to convert or contain. Then came the catastrophic war with the Eelani, whose cold efficiency made Fatunik moral reasoning look weak and self-indulgent by comparison and made the warriors of Fatune, the vaunted Tagabant, look like brittle stalks of corn after the harvest.

Each crisis demanded explanation. The Elders provided them, at first tentatively, then with increasing confidence. Failures were reinterpreted as consequences of insufficient rigor. Defeats became

evidence that the community had strayed. The Great Catastrophe itself, once understood as the result of accumulated technological and social failures, was slowly reframed as divine punishment for deviation from proper relationship with Fatune.

Inquiry began to look like indulgence. Questions began to sound like doubt. And doubt, in a world still reeling from collapse, felt dangerous.

The Night Hall noticed. It argued. Its couriers brought carefully reasoned objections to the Deep Pool at Juuj, citing cases where rigid interpretation had made crises worse, where local adaptation had saved lives, where insisting on certainty had prevented the flexibility needed to survive. Juuj listened less and less.

By the time the Elders fell, overthrown by Tonedor Rumpet and the movement that became the New Authority, the shift was already complete. Rumpet did not create a new doctrine; he stripped away the remnants of the old uncertainty and replaced it with something harder and cleaner, but ultimately far more brittle.

The New Authority

Beshquahoek was built at impossible speed. The town rose in less than a decade, its beautifully curved double-walls higher than ever seen before, its streets laid out in long graceful arcs that rejected the organic sprawl of older settlements. Everything about it announced order imposed from above.

The New Authority brought with it a reorganized understanding of Fatune's demands. Innovation became sin. Technological development became contamination. Difference became threat. What had once been a faith rooted in observation and consequence became a system rooted in obedience and suppression.

This was not simply theology. It was governance through theological enforcement. Tagabant camps multiplied along every frontier. Inspectors from the Meyajo Tagabant and the Candle Makers traveled with writs that could override local authorities. Texts were reviewed

and many were destroyed. The Kahila were crushed in campaigns that prioritized symbolic victory over practical outcome. Anyone who questioned the new interpretation could be labeled heretic, which carried consequences ranging from exile to execution depending on how visible the questioning had been.

The logic was simple and, in its way, coherent. If the Great Catastrophe resulted from technological hubris, then preventing the next catastrophe required preventing technological development. If deviation from proper practice angered Fatune, then uniformity of practice was the only safety. If local interpretation led to chaos, then centralized authority was the only answer.

The problem was not the logic. The problem for many was that Fatune does not actually behave the way the New Authority claims.

The Weather Speaks

Rain does not fall according to doctrine.

In the year 1731, the western Dominion experienced perfect compliance with ritual calendars, perfect adherence to approved agricultural methods, and the worst drought in living memory. Crops failed across three provinces. The New Authority's explanation was that hidden sins must exist, that someone somewhere had deviated in ways not yet discovered. Inspections intensified. Confessions were extracted. Communities tore themselves apart looking for the contamination that would explain their suffering.

Meanwhile, in Mobalbesq, the same drought was met with immediate practical adaptation. Communes shifted to crops that required less water. Irrigation schedules were revised. Fire rituals were adjusted to account for the increased risk of uncontrolled burns. No one looked for sin. They looked for solutions. Losses were still heavy, but fewer people starved and they thanked Fatune for helping them through it.

The next year, rain returned to both regions. In the Dominion, this was treated as proof that the purification had worked. In Mobalbesq, it was treated as weather.

This pattern repeats endlessly. Dominion authorities insist that proper observance prevents catastrophe. The Outer Lands insist that proper observance is paying attention to what actually happens and responding accordingly. Both claim to honor Fatune. Both cite tradition. The difference lies in whether tradition is allowed to learn from experience.

The hard-working scholars of the Runes of Bye maintain detailed records of weather patterns, crop yields, engineering successes and failures going back centuries. These records show clearly that catastrophe does not correlate with moral deviation. It correlates with environmental factors, with decisions made decades earlier whose consequences were not foreseen, with systems pushed beyond their tolerances. Good people suffer. Bad people prosper. Fatune rises on both and burns both without apparent preference.

To the New Authority, these records are dangerous. They suggest that Fatune's behavior might be interpretable through observation rather than received doctrine. They suggest that local communities might understand their own conditions better than distant authorities. They suggest that flexibility might work better than uniformity.

These are not abstract theological disputes. They are questions about who has the right to make decisions and on what basis.

The Problem of Distance

The Fatunik Dominion has never attacked the Outer Lands directly. In the centuries of the reign of House Moballeq, the Tagabant were well aware of how extremely foolish that would be. In the popular mind, even within the most conservative and traditionalist regions, where the word of the Elders, and then of the New Authority, is treated as finished law, even there, the folks in the Runes and Mobalbesq, and even the Ny Lands, are thought of as fellow walkers in the light of Fatune, even if they have strayed from the narrow path. And every few decades, someone in the Dominion announces that the "problem" of the Outer Lands has finally been solved.

The announcement often follows a proposed and fanciful map

revision, a new administrative charter, or a confident speech delivered far from the places in question. The language varies but the promise is the same. Integration. Stabilization. Harmonization of practice. The outer landers are coming around to the light. The region long described as unruly will at last be made legible.

What follows is also predictable. Tagabant patrol routes are extended. More inspectors and watchers are appointed with authority, supposedly, to override local decisions to the "lost" regions. The Fatunik Center attempts to assess taxes, according to models that assume conditions which do not actually exist on the ground, not least of which are the fact that the Outer Land provinces have never in all these centuries paid taxes to the Dominion. A few "model cooperative" projects are launched. A granary is donated somewhere in the Ny Lands, built to specifications designed for a different climate. A traditional Fatunik shrine is commissioned in a Mobali village, staffed by Volunteers from a faraway province who do not speak the local dialect, don't know any of the Fire songs, and do not understand why their advice is studiously ignored. A crew sent to assist with road extension is meant to signal seriousness to the magisters and scholars of the Runes, but it is routed through terrain that is impassable three months of the year. The Runiks sigh: if only they had asked to look at the *documents*...

For a season or two, from the reports being sent back to the Loyal Scribes of Fatune in Beshqauhoek, things even appear to be working. They speak of progress, compliance, gratitude.

Then the weather turns. Or the harvest fails in just one commune. Or an argument in the Night Hall drags on too long and spills into action and the collaborative project is shut down. A Nylander guardian declines to enforce a ruling they never agreed to. An unwanted structure in Mobalbesq catches fire. A ship arrives in Selaron from a port that should not exist according to Dominion's maps of "the world". And suddenly the outer regions have slipped, once again, out of the hands that thought they held them.

Dominion functionaries mistake this pattern for incompetence or resistance. Their error is assuming the Outer Lands behave like a system that wants to be governed from a distance.

Categories That Do Not Hold

Most attempts at external governance fail before the first order is issued, because they begin with the wrong question.

"What are the Outer Lands?" asks the administrator from Beshquahoek.

The answer depends entirely on who is listening. For folks in the region, the question itself sounds like an insult. To the Magisters of Byenung, the region is a set of ongoing arguments, each provisionally resolved until new evidence arrives. To the Communes of Mobalbesq, it is a lived landscape of obligation and rupture, where authority must be visible and accountable or it is meaningless. And that view is not a belief system; it is a response to centuries of unaccountable authority. To the Nylanders, it is a network of roads, treaties, and kinship lines that extend beyond any single jurisdiction; the very idea of lands belonging to someone feels absurd to them.

None of these definitions translate cleanly into the bureaucratic languages that have been raised into a monumental art form in the Dominion, and widely adopted in a different manner in the Rider provinces. Attempts to collapse the eastern provinces into a single category strip away the very mechanisms that allow the region to function at all.

A Dominion official arrives with a standardized tax assessment. The assessment assumes stable population, predictable yields, fixed property boundaries and a political relationship that has only ever existed in the minds of Dominion revisionists and revanchists. No part of the Outer Lands has been part of the Dominion in over a millennium. And aside from all that... In the Ny Lands, population and property is mobile. In Mobalbesq, land ownership is illegal and yields swing wildly year to year. In the Runes, property disputes are resolved through arguments that may take decades, and boundaries shift when engineering works that have been planned for decades and executed with precision make permanent changes to water flows.

The Dominion official insists the assessment must be applied anyway, because uniformity is necessary for fair governance. The negotiators

from Byenung and Selaron point out that uniformity in this case means punishing communities for circumstances beyond their control, rewarding others for accidents of geography and of course not to mention, utterly ignoring reality. In the Ny Lands, tribal leaders encountering such officials stare at them in disbelief, typically saying nothing at all. The Outer Landers simply don't cooperate. The official reports resistance. Penalties are threatened. The overall relationship becomes less cooperative, not more. A decade later, the whole routine repeats itself.

From the Dominion point of view, it looks like chaos and deliberate obstruction of Fatune's instructions. Within Mobalbesq, the Runes and the Ny Lands, it is the recognition that laws designed for one context cause harm when imposed on another, and that doing harm should be avoided when possible.

Authority Without Finality

In highly organized regions like the Dominion's core provinces or the United Rider territories, authority works by promising an end point. Once a law is passed, a border drawn, a tax assessed, a guild regulation promulgated, a decision announced by the Cann of Bordered or the Shining Temple of Fatune in Beshquahoeck, the matter is considered settled until formally reopened. Stability is achieved by discouraging revisitation.

The provinces of the Outer Lands operate on the opposite assumption. Nothing is final. Every agreement contains within it the expectation of revision. This does not mean nothing holds. Compacts here can be astonishingly durable, lasting generations. But they endure because they are continuously renegotiated, not because they are insulated from challenge.

A grain-sharing agreement between two Mobalbesq communes might be renewed annually for fifty turns. Each renewal involves a full assembly where the terms are read aloud and anyone can object. Most years, no one does. The agreement continues. But in a bad year, when one commune's harvest fails and the other's does not, the terms are adjusted. The adjustment is not considered a violation of the original

compact. It is considered the compact working as intended, flexible enough to survive stress.

Efforts to impose final authority trigger resistance not because people here reject order, but because they distrust permanence. Conditions change. What worked last year may not work this year. Everybody knows that. Fatune knows that. A ruling that makes sense in good times may kill people in bad times. Insisting that a decision cannot be revisited feels like insisting that the future must resemble the past, regardless of what actually happens. To some it may even feel like the Dominion representatives are saying that Fatune does not actually look over all and see all, in essence a *reductio ad absurdum* of their whole claim to authority.

The Night Hall exemplifies this pragmatic outlook. It produces no edicts that cannot be argued against, no decisions immune to reconsideration. What it produces instead is procedure. When disagreements cannot be resolved locally, they can be brought to the Hall where they will be heard, recorded, and argued until some provisional consensus emerges. That consensus may not satisfy everyone. It may not even be correct. But it keeps the disagreement from becoming violence, and violence postponed is violence diminished.

The Dance Goes On

The Outer Lands invite governance attempts from external powers because they matter. They sit astride routes no one can afford to ignore. They contain knowledge, labor, and connections that destabilize neat narratives of control. Leaving them entirely alone is not an option for a power that hopes to endure.

At the same time, fully governing them would require accepting that laws are provisional, that authority is shared, and that outcomes cannot always be predicted or measured in advance. It would require admitting that centralized interpretation of Fatune's will might be less effective than distributed observations of Fatune's behavior.

This is a lesson learned repeatedly and forgotten just as often. Each

new generation believes it has found the lever its predecessors missed. Each is surprised when the region responds with neither rebellion nor submission, but with reinterpretation.

When Tagabant authorities arrive at the Wildwind Feast to arrest some romperi master thief during the Festival, they tend think they are asserting control over a symbolic moment. They are demonstrating their ability to keep the Saskan Lands safe, a role that many outside the Dominion actually appreciate. They are also demonstrating to the Outer Lands that the New Authority considers symbols more important than stability. The arrest happened. The Kahila was taken. The Festival had to stand aside. And across the Outer Lands, communities that had been foolish enough to minimize the reach of Fatune's warriors remember that they are still being watched by the Center.

The New Fatunik Authority believes it is preventing catastrophe through enforcement of correct practice. The Outer Lands believe catastrophe is more likely when people stop paying attention to consequences. Both claim to serve Fatune. Both cite tradition. Ultimately, their conflict has nothing to do with belief. It is about method, about who decides, about whether survival requires uniformity or adaptation.

What Fatune Does Not Say

Fatune rises every morning and sets every evening. It warms the fields and burns the unwary. It enables life and ends it. It does all of this without commentary, without judgment anyone can verify, without answering the prayers some offer or the curses others mutter when crops fail again.

The Noonday Scribes insist that this silence can be interpreted through proper study of approved texts as interpreted by recognized authorities. The Night Hall argues that silence is just silence, and that the only reliable interpretation of Fatune's behavior is observation of what actually happens followed by adjustment based on those observations.

Neither position can be proven. Fatune does not clarify. And so the argument continues, in Night Hall chambers and communal

assemblies and around cooking fires where Nylander guards discuss which contracts to accept and which to decline based on whether the people offering them seem to understand that the roads have shifted, as they do, and the old routes no longer work the way they used to.

The Outer Lands do not resist governance because they are lawless. They resist it because they are already governed, by weather, by historical memory, by argument, and by the accumulated scars of learning which approach keeps people alive and which approach, however well-intentioned, ends with empty granaries and mass graves.

Those who forget this tend to leave quickly. Those who remember it learn to govern sideways, accepting that influence matters more than control and that the best you can hope for is to be heard when the next crisis comes and decisions must be made quickly by people who know the ground under their feet.

Fatune rises. The work continues. And somewhere in the chambers of the monumental Temple of Fatune in Beshquahoek, yet another plan is being drafted that will solve the problem of the Outer Lands once and for all.

It will fail for the same reasons the last one did. By the time that becomes clear, the people who designed it will have moved on to other problems, and the people of the Outer Lands will still be there, arguing about water rights and burn schedules and whether the latest Night Hall argument about sediment patterns has any practical application, because someone has to keep paying attention and it clearly will not be anyone who governs from a distance.

In a Mobalbesq field, new grain pushes through soil enriched by last season's controlled burn. A young and enthusiastic Fire singer walks the rows at dawn, checking growth patterns, making notes that will inform next year's ritual calendar, singing a song in praise of Fatune's warmth. The sunrise behind her, indifferent and essential, warms her back. She does not pray for favors. She observes, records, and adjusts. This is how Fatune is honored here, not through submission but through attention. The difference matters more than anyone in

Beshquahoeck will ever understand.

Trade and Risk

The crate smells of cinnamon and something else, sharper, that the merchant cannot identify.

He is standing in a Selaron warehouse at dawn, watching a Mobali ship's cargo being unloaded. The crate in question came from somewhere past the Forgh, transferred ship to ship through ports whose names he has heard but cannot pronounce. Inside are spices that will sell in Terpinol for three times what he paid, assuming the crate survives the overland journey, assuming the roads stay open, assuming the Nylander guards he hired show up at the rendezvous point. They have never yet not showed up. But you never know.

He has been in this business for twelve years. He knows better than to assume anything.

The dock master, a woman named Shess with forearms like bridge cables and a voice that carries over storm wind, marks the crate with chalk. "Overland to Terpinol via Southern Ring to the Canal?"

"If it's still open all the way."

"It is. For now." She does not elaborate. She never does. The merchant pays her information fee, a small leather pouch of mixed coins that she weighs by hand without counting. She nods, hands him a folded note with routes marked in a shorthand he has learned to read. Two alternate paths are included. The third has been crossed out. Something happened there recently. He does not ask what. Questions cost extra and the answers are rarely comforting.

This is trade in the Outer Lands. Not the idea of it, not the economic theory, but the actual work. The smell of exotic cargo mixed with dock tar and sweat. The weight of a route-marker note in your pocket

that might be obsolete by the time you reach the fork in the road. The constant calculation of risk against reward, distance against time, trust against verification.

What Moves and Why

Mobali ships carry volume.

A vessel called the Second Intention works the Pavan River route, captained by a woman named Duangao who has been running cargo for thirty years and knows every sandbar, every seasonal current shift, every port master who can be bribed and every one who cannot. Her ship moves upriver loaded with Mobali grain, Selaron-processed fish packed in salt, textiles from communes that specialize in fabric production, and spices from the Forgh that have been transferred through three different ships before reaching her deck.

The spices alone make the trip worthwhile. Forgh explorers bring goods that cannot be grown anywhere in the Saskan Lands. Cardamom that tastes like smoke and honey. Pepper so sharp it makes your eyes water. Dried fruits whose origins are vague and whose flavors are impossible to describe to someone who has never tried them. And of course: the Forghan Weed. These goods command prices in northern cities that make the risks of river transport look modest by comparison.

But volume matters more than luxury. Duangao's real profit comes from grain contracts with Rider provinces that need to supplement local production. A bad harvest in the western territories means high demand for Mobali surplus. A good harvest means prices drop but competition with the Settan Lands is fiercer. Duangao watches weather reports from across the Lands the way some people watch the stars. She adjusts her routes and her prices based on information that most merchants do not have access to and would not know how to interpret if they did.

On the Settan River, smaller vessels move faster and take bigger risks. A boat called Risk Properly Assessed (the name is a Nylander joke) runs cargo that cannot wait. Fresh fish that will spoil in three days.

Documents that must reach Byenung before a Night Hall session begins. Passengers willing to pay triple rates to shave two days off the journey. The captain is a sint with otter features and the kind of laugh that makes you nervous until you realize she laughs at everything, including genuine danger.

She once outran a Tidejack raid by unloading half her cargo mid-river, gaining just enough speed to reach a stretch too shallow for pursuit. The cargo she dumped was insured. The passengers were not. No one complained. They had paid for speed, not safety. She delivered both.

The Byenung Factor

Byenung does not export much grain. It exports competence.

A Byenung mason might work nine months of the year in other provinces, in the western Rider territories, overseeing the reconstruction of a bridge that has collapsed twice using local methods. He would bring his own tools, his own measuring devices, and his own apprentice who takes notes constantly and asks so many questions that it makes local builders uncomfortable.

The bridge will not collapse again. The mason's reputation depends on this, and reputation is the only currency that matters in his trade. When the project finishes, he will return to Byenung with payment in coin, material goods, and contracts for future work. More importantly, he will bring back observations. What worked. What failed. What local conditions require adaptation of standard Byenung techniques.

These observations will be filed with the engineering guilds, stored in the archives of the Night Hall, debated, tested, and incorporated into the collective knowledge that makes Byenung builders the most sought-after in the Saskan Lands.

Beshquahoeck is the proof.

The city was built in record time as a symbol of the New Authority's power and vision. Its walls are impressively high and curve around the town in way that awes anyone who sees it for the first time. Its

streets are laid in perfect arcs. Its central plaza can hold ten thousand people without crowding. Every angle was calculated. Every stone was placed with precision. The architecture announces order, permanence, and control.

What the New Authority never announced was that the city would have been impossible without the small army of Byenung professionals hired to make it work. Masons who understood load-bearing calculations that local builders had never considered. Carpenters who could frame structures tall enough to inspire awe without collapsing under their own weight. Plumbers who designed water systems that could serve a population larger than most towns and found new delights in re-shaping the ancient pools and flows under the town -- once famous as a spa. Landscape architects who turned raw construction sites into gardens that bloom on schedule.

The Tagabant paid Byenung rates, which are not cheap. They paid without negotiation because they had no choice. And Runik folk generally can't be bothered with bartering. If you don't like their price, you are free to go elsewhere. Of course no one else could do the work at the scale and speed of Byenung masters. The irony of their work in Beshqauhoek is not lost on anyone who know the story. The symbol of centralized Fatunik authority was built by people from a province that rejected that authority centuries ago and have no intention of ever returning to it.

The Byenung engineers documented their contributions, of course, and recorded that the pay was correct, the working conditions were professionally managed, and that they recommend against taking any more contracts there. The annotations have notes like: "The math was sound. What they built with it is their problem. But after two turns in the Dominion, our team felt that we could never face our rabbit-sint neighbors again if we went back there."

The Nylander Expansion

Rider Arms have dominated road protection for generations. Their network extends along every major route, their reputation is unmatched, and their contracts are honored even in regions where

Rider political authority means nothing.

But the roads are changing.

Routes that were safe a decade ago now require different approaches. Paths that were impassable have opened as climate patterns shift. Communities that had no access to trade networks are suddenly viable markets, and communities that once thrived find themselves bypassed by new routes they did not see coming.

The FTA has adapted faster than Rider Arms. Nylander guards operate on shorter contracts, adjust routes seasonally, and take jobs that traditional Rider protection considers beneath their standards or too risky to price fairly. FTA guards have no need for high-end Rider Inns. A Barból merchant who needs to reach a Mobali commune on the fringes of the Kahilakol after a stop in Juuj will not find Rider Arms willing to quote a price for getting past both Front Tagabant and Kahilakol patrols. The FTA will, and they will deliver or they will explain exactly why they could not, which is almost as valuable as success.

A trader runs textiles from Mobalbesq to markets throughout Settarune and Baranuk. She used to contract exclusively with Rider Arms. Three years ago she tried the FTA on a route through troubled territory. The contract was honored. The price was fair. The guards did not lecture her about the risks or try to upsell her on additional services she did not need.

She now uses FTA protection for seventy percent of her shipments. The remaining thirty percent are routes on well-maintained sections of the Ring where Rider Arms still maintain superior coverage, and she pays their premium rates without complaint. Competition, she says, has improved everyone's performance.

The FTA's expansion has opened regions that were previously too dangerous or too expensive to access. Small communes and villages that could not afford Rider rates can now participate in trade networks that were once beyond their reach. This creates new markets, but it also creates new vulnerabilities. A commune or village that becomes dependent on trade becomes vulnerable to disruption. A route that works for five years might fail in the sixth, and the communities that

built their economy around it must adapt or starve.

Nylanders understand this. They do not promise permanence. They promise clarity about current conditions and honest assessment of future risks. For merchants who have learned to live with uncertainty, this is often more valuable than false reassurance.

What You Cannot Insure

A Bored banking house once attempted to introduce formal insurance schemes to Outer Lands trade routes. The concept was sound. Merchants pool resources, share risk, compensate each other for losses according to actuarial tables that account for seasonal patterns and known threats.

The first year looked promising. Premiums were calculated, policies were issued, claims were paid when shipments were lost to weather or raiders. The system appeared to work.

The second year exposed the flaw.

Risk in the Outer Lands is not evenly distributed across time or space. A Mobali commune or Nylander port may lose everything while the next one over thrives. One port may go silent for reasons no one understands while another receives ships from places that should not exist according to accepted trade maps. A caravan might cross the same route through the Ny Lands successfully twenty times and fail catastrophically on the twenty-first because something changed that no actuarial table predicted.

The insurance system averaged these outcomes. This felt fair to people who had not yet been singled out by chance or circumstance. It felt like theft to the merchant whose entire shipment was lost to a freak storm while insurers pointed to policy language about "acts of Fatune" and denied the claim.

Local traders handle risk differently. They spread shipments across multiple caravans so no single loss destroys them. They diversify relationships rather than goods, building networks of people who owe them favors and to whom they owe favors in return. They accept

smaller margins in exchange for survivability. A few days spent making contacts at one of Qurol's less reputable inns can yield better insurance, in the long run, than a week of formal meetings in Bordered with guild liaisons and officials from the Rider Council.

A Mobali trader summarized it: "If you cannot afford to lose it, you should not put it all in one journey. And if you cannot survive losing it, you should not be in this business. If you don't have trustworthy connections along the way, stay home."

The Bordali insurance scheme collapsed in its fourth turn. The banking house withdrew, blaming fraud and misrepresentation of risk. Local merchants blamed a system designed for predictable conditions trying to operate in a place where predictability is the rarest commodity of all.

The Sound of a Deal

In Morilly, deals close fast.

A caravan's factotum stands in a tavern with no name painted on its door, negotiating the price of safe passage through a remote northern territory where three different groups, including Wesshewen refugees, claim jurisdiction. The FTA representative, a Nylander woman with scars across her knuckles and eyes that track every movement in the room, names a price. The representative of the Terpin-run caravan counters. The Nylander does not move. The price is the price. It accounts for the current situation on the ground, the cost of positioning guards at specific points, and the likelihood of confrontation with at least one of the groups claiming authority.

The factotum for the caravan company can accept or decline. He accepts. Coins change hands, counted quickly but not carelessly. A contract is written on a piece of cloth, not paper. Cloth is harder to forge and easier to carry. Both parties sign with marks that mean nothing to outsiders but everything to people who enforce these agreements.

The deal is done. No celebration, no ceremony. They leave. The

Nylander makes a note in a ledger that will be compiled with others, tracking routes and risks and which clients honor their obligations.

In Selaron during the Market Fair, deals take longer but mean more.

A spice merchant back from the Forgh (technically representing a trading house, though his authority is vague) negotiates with a Barból buyer over prices for the coming year. They sit in a counting house with thick walls and windows that face the harbor. Between them is a table covered with samples. Cardamom, pepper, dried fruits whose names the buyer does not recognize and a sack of the Weed, which they never mention. Each sample is smelled, tasted, evaluated.

The negotiation takes three days. Not because either party is difficult, but because the relationship matters as much as the price. The buyer wants to know he can trust next year's shipment to match this year's quality. The seller wants to know the buyer will not disappear when market conditions shift. They discuss weather patterns, shipping routes, political situations in regions neither fully understands. They share information that neither would give freely to a stranger.

On the third day, terms are agreed. The contract is written by a Byenung scribe, witnessed by three neutral parties, and filed with the Selaron trade authority. Both parties leave satisfied, though neither got everything they wanted. This is considered a successful negotiation.

The Cost of Knowing Too Much

There are things you can learn in the Outer Lands that come with a price. Recognizing where to not stick your nose can be as important as getting to the bottom of something.

An old-style Fatunik Volunteer named Issara spent a winter repairing irrigation channels near the Great Lake. She listened more than she spoke. She noticed patterns in water levels that did not match official records. She asked careful questions about where the water actually came from and where it went when the channels were closed.

The answers she received were polite, vague, carefully incomplete

and came with a certain hint of reticence that she should have picked up on. When she pressed, she was invited to observe a Night Hall session on water management. She attended. She took notes. She understood perhaps a third of what was discussed, and finally realized that most of the information she was seeking was missing intentionally. When she returned to her team, her reports were received politely and archived quickly. On her next assignment, she was sent west -- far, far to west -- all the way to the Weir Lands, far from any major waterways, on a fact-finding mission to study the ancient weirs. No reprimand was issued. No explanation was given. She understood the message.

Some knowledge is contextual. Knowing when to stop asking can be as important as knowing where to look. This is not about secrets kept maliciously. It is about information that makes sense only within specific frameworks, and some frameworks take years to learn. Outsiders who try to extract knowledge quickly often misunderstand what they are being told and use it badly. The results can be dangerous.

Traders who operate successfully in the Outer Lands learn this early. You can ask about prices, routes, conditions. You can ask about risks and how to mitigate them. But there are answers that signal you do not understand the context well enough to use the answers responsibly, and asking those questions marks you as someone to watch carefully or exclude entirely.

What Makes It Work

The Outer Lands should not function as a major economic engine. And yet.

Political authority is fractured. Weather is unpredictable. Infrastructure fails regularly. Routes change without warning. Agreements are provisional. Trust is expensive and easily lost. There are more than the average share of bandits on the roads.

And yet large volumes of high value goods move. Ships navigate rivers and marshes that should be impassable. Caravans cross plateaus

where raiders operate openly and wild animals roam. Byenung craftspeople are hired to work on projects all across the Saskan Lands. Mobali spices reach markets that have never seen a coastline. Nylander guards open routes that expand trade into regions previously isolated.

What makes it work is not trust in the abstract, but accountability in the specific. People honor contracts because their reputation depends on it and reputation is the only asset that cannot be replaced. Communities participate in trade networks because the alternatives are worse, isolation being a slower death than the risks of engagement. Institutions like the Night Hall and the Selaron Fair and the Wildwind Feast provide frameworks where disputes can be resolved without destroying the relationships that make commerce possible.

The systems are multiple and inefficient. Redundancy costs more than optimization, but redundancy survives disruption while optimized systems collapse. Multiple routes mean higher costs but better odds that something will get through. Multiple relationships mean more complexity but less vulnerability to any single failure.

This is not the trade network that central planners in Bordered or Beshquahoek would design. It is a trade network that survives when central planning fails, when dynasties collapse, when weather does not cooperate, when politics interrupt, when the ground itself shifts and forces everyone to recalculate.

A merchant's log from a caravan that crossed from Mobalbesq to Eelan last season includes this entry: "Lost two days to bridge failure. Rerouted through Ny Lands with FTA escort. Added three days but avoided Romperi activity near Kahila border. Arrived with full cargo. Profit margin reduced but acceptable. Next season, plan alternate route from start."

This is how it works. Not perfectly. Not safely. But persistently, because the people who make their living here have learned that persistence matters more than perfection and that survival requires accepting risk as cost rather than treating it as surprise.

In a Selaron counting house, a scribe records the day's transactions in ledgers that will be archived, cross-referenced, and consulted for decades, possibly longer. On the Pavan River, a Mobali ship loads cargo for the journey upriver, its captain checking weather signs and water levels with equal attention. In a Nylander camp on the high western plateau, guards prepare for tomorrow's escort duty, cleaning weapons and reviewing contract terms with the same methodical care. And somewhere on a road between provinces, a Mobali merchant calculates risk against reward for the hundredth time this season, knowing the calculation will be different tomorrow but making it anyway because this is the work, this is how value moves through a world that will not sit still, and someone has to do it or the whole fragile system stops.

The Runes of Bye

There are people who say the Runes of Bye are governed by the runes. This is not true, though it is not entirely wrong either.

What governs the Runes of Bye is work, the kind that leaves chalk on your sleeves, ink in the creases of your fingers, and a low, persistent headache from listening too closely to people who refuse to let a bad idea go unchallenged. The runes are there, absolutely. They are older than hum settlement, worn smooth by weather and human handling, standing as monuments and also embedded in bridges, culverts, retaining walls, and public steps. They are consulted, studied, interpreted, argued over, invoked, ignored, reinterpreted, and occasionally tripped on.

But it is the Byenung folk who keep the place running. And they run it the way they do everything else, by insisting that no problem is solved until it has been taken apart, labeled, debated, annotated and

put back together in a slightly different order.

Byenung

Approach Byenung by water and the city looks deliberate.

Rivers feed in and out of the Great Lake of Bye and canals run from it and back into like veins and arteries, and the powerful heart muscle making the system work is the remarkable town of Byenung. Stone embankments step down towards the lake and the canals in precise intervals, each one repaired a dozen times in different styles. Some courses are laid in the old manner with dry-fit precision, others mortared hastily during a flood year, still others reinforced with iron brackets that have since rusted to the color of dried blood. Both wind-driven and water-driven pumps creak constantly, their rhythm irregular enough that you notice when one falls silent. The air smells of wet stone, algae thick as paint, hot oil from the pumps, and paper, always paper.

Rabbit-sints, otter-sints and others swarm the docks, compact and quick, moving crates and ropes and tools with an efficiency that looks casual until you try to match it. They work in clusters, speak little to outsiders, and keep meticulous internal accounts that never quite align with anyone else's books. A warren-leader named Nemm has been running dock logistics for thirty years. She can recite the contents of any shipment from memory and will correct your manifest before you've finished reading it aloud. If she detects an error in the books, she freezes in place while staring at the numbers until a solution to the problem emerges. No one seriously tries to force the accounting issue. The system works. Which in Byenung counts as a moral argument.

Farther inland, the city grows louder. Not with shouting, but with overlapping conversations. Arguments spill from workshops and counting rooms. You can follow a single dispute for blocks, listening as it mutates with each new participant. A mason might begin it over breakfast, debating the proper slope for a drainage channel. By

midday, a canal engineer has folded in concerns about sedimentation rates. By evening, a Night Hall observer is citing a precedent from two centuries ago, and someone's niece who works part-time in the Library archives is pointing out that that precedent was later annotated as "incomplete due to winter conditions not accounted for."

Visitors often assume this is chaos. Residents call it ventilation. If you don't know what is being discussed and debated by everyone in a given neighborhood on a given day, well, that's a dead giveaway that you're from out of town.

The Great Lake

The Great Lake of Bye did not always exist in its current form. Everyone agrees on that. Disagreements begin immediately afterward.

Official histories credit early huum engineers with damming the Settan River and expanding a natural basin into a massive reservoir. It was the first large-scale civil engineering project of the post-Arrival settlers. This is true as far as it goes. What is less often said aloud is how quickly the project outpaced its own plans.

Water levels stabilized before the models predicted. Colossal sinkholes opened where the surveys showed solid bedrock, dramatically expanding the lake's footprint overnight. Sediment behaved oddly, settling in some places and churning in others according to patterns that made experienced dredgers shake their heads and request additional documentation. Fish species appeared that no one had stocked. Slender silver things with too many fins and bottom-feeders that grew larger than they should. A decade after the dam was completed, an entire cavern system flooded that was thought to be sealed, and instead of draining water away, the lake then grew by half again its planned size in a single week of perfectly ordinary weather. Evidently other cavern walls had collapsed at the same time, but letting underground flows into the lake.

Each anomaly was recorded, disputed, and provisionally explained. None were allowed to halt the work.

Today, the lake is treated with a mix of reverence and irritation. It is essential, unpredictable, and prone to answering questions no one remembers asking. Engineers monitor it obsessively, taking depth soundings at intervals measured in days rather than seasons. Children are warned not to swim too far from shore, not because of drowning, but because of currents that run wrong, pulling sideways instead of out. Old fishers refuse certain zones entirely, marking them on personal charts they will not share even with their apprentices.

Magisters insist, sincerely, that everything important has already been studied.

They do not all believe this. Late at night in the Night Hall archives, you can find annotations in cramped handwriting: Query whether expansion continues. Or: South basin temperature anomaly persists; no seasonal variations detected since Turn 987. Or, written in a margin and then heavily crossed out but still legible: Something is listening.

The Night Hall

The walls of the Night Hall rise just back from the lake, its hundreds of windows narrow, its corridors longer than many town streets, its stone always slightly cooler than expected. It was founded by the Magisters of Byenung as a place to hold debates that could not be held anywhere else.

By design, the Hall has no single chamber large enough to dominate the others. Debates migrate from room to room as participants shift, as new evidence arrives, as old voices tire and new ones take up the thread. Invitations are extended carefully and revoked rarely. Many of the Mobalbesq communes participate loudly and with little patience for abstraction. Their delegates often arrive smelling faintly of smoke,

and they have been known to walk out mid-way through a session if it strays too far from material consequence. Nylanders attend too, typically listen with faces that give nothing away except to occasionally erupt in laughter, and leave early. But they keep coming back and they listen to every word that is spoken. Representatives from Kahilakol, Kahilabeq, Pavanarune, and even the eastern reaches of Settarune appear briefly, speak obliquely, and vanish again. It is rare, but not entirely unheard-of, for an observer from Terpinol to come and stay for an extended period.

A typical Night Hall session begins in the afternoon, stretches into the small hours, and ends without resolution. This is not considered failure. What matters is that the disagreement has been contained, formalized, entered into the record. Violence postponed is violence diminished.

Shown Nywing, son of the High Magister, once remarked to a visitor that the Night Hall exists to make sure no one gets exactly what they want. He was not joking. He was standing in the Hall's western gallery at the time, hands clasped behind his back, watching two delegations argue past each other in three languages while a scribe recorded every word in a shorthand so dense it looked like embroidery.

Faith, After the Schism

The Runes of Bye are Fatunik in ancestry, but not in obedience.

Centuries ago, Byenung severed itself from the Dominion not over doctrine, but over method. The Council of the Eibar Folk demanded closure. The instructions of Fatune had expression in certain answers, in verdicts, prescriptions, settled law. The Magisters of the Runes insisted instead on process. They averred that it was evidence, revision based on discovery, and the right to revisit conclusions when new data emerged that demonstrated true devote to the light of Fatune. The break was quiet but irrevocable, and it has never been

formally healed.

Old style Fatunik volunteers are numerous here. They repair bridges, teach literacy, maintain the small shrines where travelers can light a candle to Fatune before crossing water. Tagabant authority, however, is not welcome. Their seals are politely declined at the gates. Their writs are filed as "received but not recognized." Once, a Tagabant envoy attempted to enforce a directive regarding technological restrictions amongst all Fatunik followers. He was given a lengthy tour of the extraordinary Runik canal system, then handed a thick folder of maintenance records and notes, was given a bowl of hearty hot s'lah, and asked to consider what he had seen, review the records and then explain which pumps should be shut down first and how the resulting flood damage would serve Fatune's interests. He left the province the next morning without issuing any further instructions.

Faith in the Runes is practiced as a well-pondered and tentative test, not as blind obedience. Sermons, such as they are, resemble lectures, complete with footnotes cited aloud. Fatunik rituals amongst the Runes include moments where congregants are invited to suggest amendments. Even Fire cultists from Mobalbesq who are hardly shy about their own version of Fatunik belief complain that Byenung rituals can make faith feel like paperwork.

And yet, the system produces astounding results. The greatest engineering works in the Saskan Lands regularly begin here, sketched on slate in workshops that smell of coal-smoke and damp wool. Granaries are built that can buffer an entire province through famine. Canals maintained with a precision that borders on obsessive. The Magisters would call this evidence of correctness. Their collegial critics might call it luck reinforced by stubbornness. And both groups keep detailed notes.

Living in the Runes

Life in the Runes of Bye is busy, argumentative, and exhausting.

Children learn early how to interrupt politely. There is an entire vocabulary for it, gradations of interjection that signal whether you are asking for clarification, offering correction, or preparing to disagree with the fundamental premise. Elders are respected not for the certainty of their conclusions but for the quality of their objections. A well-constructed counter-argument is a gift. Sloppy thinking is an insult.

Anxiety is common but so is pride. A canal worker will spend an hour explaining why a particular gate mechanism is superior to three previous designs, pointing out stress fractures in the old hardware with the intensity of someone describing a personal betrayal. A baker will argue about oven temperature with a precision that would make a natural philosopher weep. Market vendors debate weights and measures not to cheat but because the difference between twelve and thirteen ounces might matter in a year when grain runs short, and someone needs to remember what was actually agreed upon last time.

When storms come, the city mobilizes with a coordination that looks miraculous until you realize that every aspect of the response has been discussed and rehearsed for months, including the underlying rationale for each decision and each action. When famine threatens, both action plans *and* re-calculations begin immediately. There are no prayers for deliverance, no ritual incantations. There are inventories, projections, discussions of who has surplus and who will need it and what the terms should be. When something inexplicable happens, and something inexplicable nearly always happens, it is documented, debated until some satisfactory explanations are proposed, and then folded into practice.

The Runes endure not because they understand the world better than others, but because they refuse to ever stop asking how it works, even when the answers make them uncomfortable. That refusal has kept Byenung growing and developing and, not incidentally, free of serious conflict, longer than most cities in the Outer Lands. It has also ensured that when the lake shifts, when the standing argument fails, or

in those rare occasions when outside powers have decided that their patience has run out, the consequences are felt by everyone. Carefully recorded, thoroughly discussed and documented, and impossible to ignore.

In a workshop near the eastern docks, an huum engineer named Pavik is explaining to his apprentice why the new pump design will fail. He has sketches, calculations, and a working model made from scrap wood and wire. The apprentice listens, nods, then points out a flaw in the master's reasoning. Pavik stops mid-sentence. He looks at the model. He picks up the chalk and asks the apprentice to show him what she sees as the flaw in the design. Outside, the wind shifts over the water, and somewhere in the Night Hall, an argument that has been running for two hundred years gains a new footnote. The lamps stay lit. The work continues.

The Night Hall Library

The main façade of the Night Hall does not face the sun.

Its entrances are narrow, its windows set high and deep, its chambers arranged so that voices carry but faces do not dominate. Lamps burn low by custom, not scarcity. Oil is plentiful enough, but the founders believed that shadows encourage listening. You cannot perform well in poor light. You can only speak, and hope the words themselves are strong enough to survive scrutiny.

This is not a place for proclamations. It is a place for Arguments with a capital A, the kind that take years to construct and generations to resolve, if they resolve at all.

When Curiosity Was Still Orthodoxy

The Night Hall was founded in the Runes of Bye during a period when Fatunik doctrine still resembled inquiry more than obedience. In those days, Ingar remained the cultural heart of Eibar-speaking society, and Fatune was spoken of less as judge than as condition, as a source of nourishment that both warns and burns with neither malice nor favor.

Early Magisters believed catastrophe came not from insufficient devotion, but from refusal to observe consequences. Their answer was not ritual purity, but record-keeping, experimentation, and debate conducted with enough rigor that future generations could trace the reasoning and decide for themselves whether it still held. The Hall was meant to preserve that method when memory inevitably shortened and fear inevitably tempted people toward simpler answers.

From the beginning, it was understood that the Hall would never rule. It would persist.

The first structure was modest. It was a single stone room with benches arranged in concentric half-circles, no central podium, no place of honor. Speakers stood wherever there was space. Arguments were recorded on slate because parchment was precious and slate could be erased if the reasoning proved faulty, though the best arguments were eventually transferred to more permanent media. The room still exists, deep in the current Hall's foundation, accessible by a staircase so narrow you must turn sideways to descend. Occasionally someone goes down there to sit in the silence and remember what the Hall was supposed to be before it became what it is.

What is an Argument?

In Night Hall usage, an Argument is not a dispute. It is a structured attempt to persuade another moral system that it is acting against its own stated values.

Arguments are written first, revised extensively, then spoken aloud in chambers where the acoustics have been calculated to carry whispers to the back wall. They are named, cite history, harvest data, record engineering failures and population movements, and ritual outcomes. They acknowledge uncertainty. A well-constructed Argument includes a section titled "Where This Reasoning May Fail" and means it. They anticipate counter-arguments and record disputes, often numbering them, always addressing the strongest objections rather than the easiest.

They are often addressed, formally and repeatedly, to the Elders of Juuj.

Some of the same Arguments have been made for centuries. Sometimes with new data gathered from recent famines or floods. Sometimes with new language calibrated to shift with changes in Juuj's own doctrine. Never with violence. Never with threats. The Night Hall's position has always been that if an Argument cannot succeed on its own merits, it should not succeed at all.

This consistency has earned the Magisters a reputation for stubbornness, arrogance, and among its own members something that might be hope or might be compulsion, the inability to stop even when stopping would be wiser.

The Juuj Correspondence

When doctrinal authority shifted from Ingar to Juuj, the Night Hall followed it westward with its words.

At first, the Elders responded. Records from the early centuries show long exchanges: courteous, sharp, occasionally warm. The Elders debated beside their underground pool, water reflecting lamplight onto stone faces lined with doubt and intelligence. There were moments when it seemed the two institutions might converge, might develop a shared framework for understanding how faith and

evidence could inform one another.

Then the famines worsened. Then the wars multiplied, first with animal-sint populations who refused integration, then with Kahila rejectionists, then with the Eelani whose efficiency-worship made Fatunik morality look weak by comparison. Then the catastrophes began to stack faster than they could be explained.

The Elders' tone changed.

Fatune became less warning than verdict. The Great Catastrophe was reframed not as consequence but as punishment for deviation. Inquiry came to be seen as indulgence, questioning as weakness. Over time, replies from Juuj grew shorter, then symbolic, then ceased entirely. The last formal response arrived sixty-three years ago containing a single sentence: "Your questions are noted, your concerns are understood, and our position remains unchanged."

The Night Hall has never stopped writing and never stopped sending its emissaries and couriers to Juuj.

A Magister named Kelovann Clawing has spent forty years maintaining the Juuj Correspondence archive. His office is a narrow room on the Hall's third floor, its walls lined with shelves holding Arguments filed by date, by topic, by which Elder they were addressed to when the Elders still had names and titles that anyone outside Juuj remembered. Kelovann Clawing can recite from memory which Arguments received responses and which were ignored, and more importantly, he can tell you why: what had changed in Juuj's internal politics, what harvest failure or military defeat had shifted their priorities, what made them close ranks and stop listening.

He is not optimistic about persuading them. He simply believes someone must keep asking the right questions, even into silence.

Who Speaks

The Night Hall is no longer Fatunik in the narrow sense, though its bones are.

The Magisters of Byenung still serve as custodians. They maintain the records, chair the proceedings, ensure that procedure is followed even when tempers run hot. But the voices within are many, and the air on any given evening carries multiple languages, multiple assumptions about what constitutes proof.

Runik engineers bring tables of water levels and soil failure rates, arguing that nature responds to structure, not prayer alone. A hum woman who had spent thirty years managing canal systems near the Great Lake, once presented a forty-page analysis of sediment patterns that contradicted two centuries of accepted wisdom about how the lake drains. She was interrupted sixty-seven times. By the end of the session, three of her conclusions had been adopted provisionally, five were rejected, and the rest were filed as "requiring further observation." She returned the next season with further observations.

Mobalbesq delegates arrive smelling faintly of smoke, impatient with abstraction, demanding that belief justify itself in burned fields and rebuilt granaries. They do not sit quietly. A Fire singer named Oresh once stood on his chair to make a point about food storage and would not step down until someone explained how a particular theological position would prevent rats from eating grain. No one could. The position was revised.

Nylander listeners tend to attend briefly, speak rarely, and leave behind pithy warnings and observations that make sense only months later. They watch more than they talk, and when they do speak it is usually to point out that a proposed solution will fail in practice because it assumes cooperation that does not exist or road conditions that have already changed. They are almost never wrong about this, which makes their silences unnerving.

Quiet observers from Pavanarune, Eibar, Kahilakol and even further afield appear and vanish. Some speak with accents that do not match their appearance. Some ask questions that should be simple but

somehow pull entire Arguments into new shapes. Once, a delegate arrived who claimed no affiliation and spoke for three hours about patterns in crop failures that matched no known weather system. The Magisters tried to follow up. The delegate was gone by morning, and no one could agree on what they had looked like. When Terpin visitors and guests arrive and begin to speak, the Hall sends out for days' worth of food stuffs and s'lah and the scribes scurry to gather up extra empty scrolls and fresh pots of ink.

Rabbit-sints tend to cluster near the walls in family groups, whispering among themselves, tracking patterns in the arguments that huum participants miss. They rarely speak in sessions, but their observations are sought afterward. A warren-elder named Phoss has a reputation for remembering who said what in which session going back decades, and more than once an Argument has been won or lost based on precedent she recalled that everyone else had forgotten.

The Architecture of Containment

The Hall's design forces humility.

There is no single chamber large enough for grandstanding. Arguments that grow too large must split across multiple rooms, with runners carrying updates between them. This fragments consensus, prevents any one voice from dominating, and occasionally produces bizarre outcomes where two halves of the same debate reach opposite conclusions and must be reconciled later.

Acoustics vary by room. The northern chambers amplify whispers, making quiet precision more effective than volume. The southern galleries are designed to muddle echoes, forcing speakers to articulate clearly or be misunderstood. The deepest chambers, carved into bedrock beneath the building's foundation, are so acoustically dead that your own voice sounds strange in your ears. These are used for Arguments too sensitive or too uncertain to risk in more public

spaces.

Seating is never assigned. You sit where you can find space, which means high-ranking Magisters, in their fine robes and elegant headgear, might end up squeezed between a Mobali farmer and a sint courier, forced to listen to perspectives they would otherwise avoid. This is deliberate. The founders believed that proximity to unfamiliar reasoning was the only reliable cure for certainty.

Lamps are adjusted seasonally. In winter, when arguments run long and tempers fray more easily, they burn brighter to prevent fatigue. In summer, they dim slightly to keep the rooms cool. Once, an overzealous reformer proposed standardizing the lighting year-round. The proposal was debated for three months, rejected, and the reformer was quietly assigned to archival work where his passion for consistency could do less harm.

Why Power Hates the Night Hall

The Night Hall has no army. It issues no edicts. It controls no land.

What it produces is memory with teeth.

Every authority in the Dominion, from the Council of the Eibar Folk to the Elders of Juuj to the New Fatunik Authority of Beshquahoek, has regarded the Night Hall as irritating at best, dangerous at worst. Its Arguments refuse to stay buried. They resurface whenever policies fail, whenever famine returns, whenever a pogrom produces the opposite of its intended effect. You cannot simply declare that a particular approach is correct when the Night Hall has six hundred pages of documentation explaining why it failed last time, and the time before that, and what the consequences were for the people who insisted otherwise.

To the New Authority, the Hall is worse than heresy. It is evidence that another Fatunik path existed and still exists, one that is rigorous, questioning, open to revision and might spread if enough people

discover that it works better than the alternative.

That is why the Tagabant tolerate the Night Hall but watch it closely. That is why certain folks are no longer welcome in its chambers. That is why sponsorship of particular plans, especially those involving someone like Stannielus Quinn'aarql, who represents everything the current orthodoxy fears, is treated as provocation rather than discourse.

A Tagabant inspector still visits the Hall twice a year, ostensibly to renew diplomatic credentials between the Dominion and the Runes of Bye. In practice, he sits in on sessions, takes notes, and reports back to Beshquahoek on which Arguments are gaining traction and which Magisters are becoming influential. His presence changes nothing. Arguments continue. Notes are taken on both sides. The inspector leaves with a stern nod, and everyone understands that tolerance has limits that have not yet been defined.

Where Arguments Go to Age

If the Night Hall is where arguments are made, the Library is where they are forced to grow up.

You enter the Library sideways through a corridor off the Hall's eastern wing, past a desk where a clerk checks credentials without looking up. She has been doing this for twenty years. She knows by the sound of your footsteps whether you belong here, and if you do not, she will ask questions that reveal your ignorance gently enough that you can retreat without losing face.

The first rooms feel ordinary. Study tables are worn smooth by generations of elbows, shelves close enough to touch both sides at once, lamps adjusted low to preserve eyesight and keep tempers cool during long research sessions. Then the stairs begin.

They go up into mezzanines that overlook debate chambers, where scholars can listen to Arguments while cross-referencing claims in

real time. A researcher named Beldran Strongfoot works in one such space, barely large enough for a desk and two chairs, with a narrow window that looks down on the Hall's main western chamber. He has witnessed three hundred Arguments from that window. He has seen tempers flare, voices rise, fists slam tables. He has also seen the moment when someone's face changes because they have realized their position cannot hold—the precise instant when stubbornness gives way to reluctant revision. That moment, he likes to say, is why the Night Hall works at all.

The stairs also go down, step by measured step into older, quieter places where the air cools and the lamps change color to preserve inks that no longer exist anywhere else. Some texts down here are so fragile they can only be consulted under supervision, pages turned with wooden spatulas, breathing regulated to avoid condensation. Some are sealed not because they are forbidden but because they are unfinished arguments that were interrupted by war, famine, or death, left in states that subsequent scholars have been reluctant to resolve.

What Is Kept

The Night Hall Library holds the second-largest collection of books, scrolls and other artifacts in the Saskan Lands, surpassed only by Terpinol's Academy. But size is not its defining trait. Classification is.

Texts are not arranged by author or subject alone, but by argumentative lineage. A treatise on canal step construction may sit beside a moral debate on public safety, which in turn cross-indexes to a famine response charter written three centuries later. The logic is simple: ideas do not exist in isolation. They respond to other ideas, refine them, contradict them, build on their failures. To understand any single position fully, you must understand what it was arguing against and what later arguments it provoked.

Margins matter more than titles here. A book might be unremarkable in itself, but if it carries annotations from five generations of

Magisters, each responding to the previous layer of commentary, it becomes invaluable. Some volumes are more annotation than original text, pages thick with ink in different colors marking different eras of debate.

There are rooms devoted entirely to annotations on single works. One such room houses responses to an engineering manual written four hundred years ago about the proper construction of dock steps. The manual itself is fourteen pages. The annotations fill three walls, floor to ceiling: calculations revised, assumptions challenged, case studies from docks that succeeded and docks that failed, arguments about whether the failures were due to poor execution or flawed theory, further arguments about what proper execution even means when every dock faces different water conditions.

One scholar has spent eight years in that room. She is writing a comprehensive analysis of how the concept of proper slope has evolved and why seventeen different Magisters have defined it seventeen different ways. She expects to finish in another three years, at which point someone else will likely annotate her work.

This is not considered eccentric. It is considered responsible.

Credentials and Waiting

Access is not open. It is earned.

To use the outer stacks, the public-facing collection that includes basic references, published treatises, and annotated histories, one must present a credential from a recognized body: a Commune council, a guild, a Rider bureau, a Fatunik order, a Nylander kin-group. The requirements are not onerous, but they ensure that anyone using the Library has some institutional standing and thus some accountability for what they do with the knowledge.

To move inward, past the public stacks into the working archives where Arguments are drafted and revised, one applies. The

application requires a statement of purpose, letters of reference, and often an interview with a senior librarian who will ask uncomfortable questions about your motivations and whether you understand the ethical weight of the materials you want to access.

To go down, into the deepest chambers where the oldest and most contested materials are kept, one waits. Months, years, sometimes. Requests are reviewed by committees whose minutes are themselves archived. Denials are polite, specific, and rarely explained fully. Approval often comes with conditions: supervised access, limited copying, mandatory annotation submission afterward.

The logic is simple. Knowledge here is not neutral. It has already been used to justify bridges, laws, exclusions, and interventions that killed people or saved them or both. Anyone who touches it is expected to leave fingerprints in return. Your own annotations, your own questions, your own additions to the record let future scholars know what you were thinking so they can judge whether you were right.

A Day in the Stacks

In the late afternoon, when the Hall's arguments begin to heat up overhead, the Library grows busiest.

A mixed-heritage mason with hands still smelling of lime and wet stone argues quietly with a Byenung jurist over a passage written before either of their grandparents were born. The passage concerns the legal liability of engineers whose designs fail during floods. The mason insists the passage is being misread. It specifies ordinary floods, not catastrophic ones, and the distinction matters because ordinary floods can be planned for while catastrophic ones cannot. The jurist counters that the distinction is meaningless if engineers claim every failure was caused by a catastrophic event. They are not angry. They are focused, both taking notes, both aware that this argument may eventually inform a Night Hall session on updated

building codes.

A Nylander observer sits cross-legged on the floor, reading a shipping compact upside down. Literally upside down, with the book rotated 180 degrees because Nylander contract notation sometimes embeds secondary meanings in the visual patterns of the text and reading it from the wrong angle reveals different clauses. She is listening more to the rhythm of the debate upstairs than to the words on the page, tracking which Arguments are gaining support and which are stalling.

A rabbit-sint family cluster works through a ledger together, ears twitching as they compare marginal notes that disagree by a single line item in a grain shipment from ninety years ago. The disagreement matters because it affects how subsequent yields are calculated, which in turn affects current estimates of sustainable harvest rates. They whisper among themselves in a dialect that blends huum language with sounds that huum throats cannot produce, rapid clicks and soft whistles that carry numerical data more efficiently than words.

No one raises their voice. That happens elsewhere. Here, disagreements are settled by citation, by precedent, by the slow accumulation of "yes, but" that eventually produces something closer to truth than any single perspective could manage alone.

How It Differs from Terpinol

Terpinol's Academy studies the world to understand it. They collect knowledge for its own sake, believing that comprehension is inherently valuable regardless of application.

The Night Hall Library studies how people tried to understand the world, and what happened next.

A Terpinol scholar might ask whether a canal system could be built, what the optimal dimensions would be, which materials would last longest. A Night Hall scholar asks whether the last five attempts justified their cost, who paid it, which communities were blamed

when it failed anyway, and whether the failures were due to bad engineering or bad governance or both.

Neither approach is wrong. But only one keeps a record of the arguments that followed the flood, and only one archives the apologies that were never issued and the reparations that were never paid.

The Subterranean Rooms

The deepest chambers are quiet enough to hear your own breathing change.

Down here, texts are older, stranger, and less resolved. Early Fatunik debates from Ingar sit beside Juuj-era rebuttals written in cramped, angry hands that pressed so hard the pen sometimes tore through the page. Some scrolls are sealed not because they are forbidden, but because they are incomplete due to arguments interrupted mid-sentence by events that made their completion irrelevant or impossible.

It is rumored that certain records here predate hum settlement entirely. Officially, no such texts exist. The official position is that everything in the Library was created by hum or sint hands, in languages that can be read and interpreted according to known methods.

Unofficially, librarians do not laugh when asked about pre-Arrival materials. They say nothing. They make no confirmations. They also make no denials. A researcher who spends enough time in the deepest stacks and who has earned enough trust might be shown a particular shelf and left alone for a few hours. What they find there, they do not discuss. Not because they are forbidden, but because no one would believe them, and attempting to explain would compromise access for everyone else.

A Magister spent six months in the deep archives two decades ago.

When he emerged, he was thinner, grayer, and he refused all interviews. He submitted a single annotation to the records: "Some questions should be asked more carefully." He died three years later. His notes were sealed at his request and will not be opened for another fifty years.

Why It Matters

When the Night Hall sends an Argument to Juuj, it is not improvising. It is drawing on centuries of recorded failure, partial success, and hard-earned humility. Every sentence carries weight because someone once paid for it with a collapsed dock, a lost harvest, or a community that did not survive the winter.

The Library is not a monument to knowledge. It is a tool for survival. It exists to prevent the same mistakes from being made the same way for the same stupid reasons while claiming they are new insights that have never been tried before.

This is why the Library endures, even when some authorities would prefer it burn. It remembers too much. And in a world where orthodoxy keeps reinventing itself as certainty, the Night Hall Library remains an inconvenient reminder that someone has already tried this and wrote down exactly how it went wrong, in language clear enough that anyone who bothers to read can understand what is about to happen next.

That, in Byenung, counts as hope.

In a chamber three levels down, a young scholar reads by lamplight that makes her eyes ache. The text is old, the language archaic, the reasoning dense. She does not understand half of it yet. But she takes notes in margins that future readers will annotate in their turn, continuing a conversation that began before she was born and will continue after she dies. Overhead, the main evening session is

reaching its peak, voices rising in argument that will be recorded, filed, and referenced for decades. The lamps burn low. The work continues.

Mobalbesq Province

The field burns at dawn.

Not by accident. Never by accident. Three generations of the Marnosh Torvakars stand at the edge watching their winter wheat go up in controlled rows of flame, the fire advancing in a line so straight you could use it to survey property. The smoke rises white at first, then gray as it reaches the stubble, then black-brown as the deep roots catch and the soil itself begins to exhale centuries of carbon. The eldest, a hum woman whose hands are scarred from fifty turns of this work, nods once. The timing is right. The wind is right. By tomorrow the ash will have cooled enough to work back into the earth, and by next month the field will be planted again in something the soil has agreed to feed.

A Rider patrol passes on the road above. They do not stop. They have learned that in Mobalbesq, fire is not an emergency. It is a conversation.

The Communes of Fire

Despite the Moballeq legacy and the key role that Selaron town plays in Saskan economics, Mobalbesq province has no official capital. It has gatherings.

Each commune governs itself through assemblies that meet in open courtyards, under market pavilions, beside irrigation channels where

everyone can hear the water and remember what they are arguing about. Decisions are binding because everyone present has had the chance to object, and anyone who did not attend forfeits the right to complain later. This is not written law. It is simply how things have always worked since the Moballeq clan fell. It is the way stones fall downward and fire rises.

A typical assembly runs loud. In the Drashkar Commune, west of Morilly, a debate over grazing rights lasted from noon until well past dark. Voices rose. A clay cup was thrown. Not at anyone, just thrown, because the man holding it needed both hands to make his point and forgot he was holding it. A rabbit-sint matron named Talenr stood on a grain sack and explained, with the patience of someone who has done this before, why the proposed boundary shift would create problems in three years when the irrigation schedule rotated. She was ignored for twenty minutes, then what she was saying settled in and once everyone was listening, the proposal was amended on the spot. No vote was taken. The speaker who had made the original proposal simply nodded and sat down, and the next item was called.

This system looks chaotic to outsiders. It is not. It is expensive. Time, energy, and the emotional labor of being shouted at by your neighbor's cousin's lover are the price of legitimacy. The Communes accept this cost because the alternatives are well-known: unquestionable authority, rule from a distance, orders handed down by people who have never smelled your fields burning but will still demand a share of their yield.

The Mobali are long done with all of that.

Rabbit and other sints are common here, especially in agricultural roles. They work in extended family warrens, coordinating hand-pollination schedules with a precision that looks instinctive but is in fact learned and refined over generations. During pollination season, you can see them moving through the fields at first light, brushes and small tools passed from hand to hand, ears swiveling to track the wind. They keep largely to themselves socially, even when working in the same commune with huum or other animal-sints, not out of fear

but preference. Fire cult rituals are loud, unpredictable, and not always kind to sensitive hearing.

Mixt folk are everywhere too and unremarkable. Mobalbesq is uninterested in purity of form. Survival is the only pedigree that matters. Capability is the only mark of status. A woman with tiger-stripping along her forearms might run a pottery works. A man whose eyes track movement like a lizard's might keep the commune's financial records. No one comments. The work speaks for itself.

The Mother of Fire

Across the Mobali Communes, faith that has fractured is converging again.

Her names vary. The Mother of Fire. She-Who-Burns-like-Fatune. The Ash-Wind. But most commonly, Monmar Massachawa. And to a few simply Mother. Her figure is unmistakable. She is not a creator so much as a keeper of thresholds. Fire clears. Fire warns. Fire punishes complacency. Her hair is said to crackle with static when storms approach. She has taught the children of the communes to watch the winds, not the sky. When the air stills unnaturally, then fires must be banked low and livestock moved uphill. When winds rise too fast, then offerings are burned early. Not to appease, but to show you are paying attention. The spirit of Fatune is not up there, children. It is here, in the spark that is in your hands.

In a fire temple outside of Selaron, a famed fire singer, Kareshin Mora of the Third Hearth, leads morning devotions. The temple is small, open on three sides, with a fire pit at the center that never goes completely cold. Kareshin Mora does not preach salvation. He walks the perimeter pouring oil in a careful line, then lights it with a gesture so practiced it looks casual. The flames rise, blue at the base, gold at the tips. He chants while they burn. Of a granary that failed because someone ignored moisture readings. About a commune that prospered because they burned their fallow fields on schedule. Another legend

extolling the difference between real faith-in-practice and wishful thinking. The gathering is only thirty people, all huum, farmers mostly, a few merchants, a Nylander traveler in the back. They listen without responding. When the flames die, they leave. No one lingers. The fire-talker knows all the calls, all the responses, all hymns and song cycles. He knew what needed to be sung.

Fatunik faith blends easily with the communal ways of the Mobali folk. Fatune, in Mobalbesq, is not destiny, not something remote. Fatune is timing. Fatune is doing. The Mother of Fires did not inherit the Moballeq mantle in order to decide outcomes or give directions. She simply knows when certain outcomes are no longer avoidable and she lets her children know. Mobali fire cultists are well trained. For all their variety in appearance and skills, this makes them dangerous negotiators and excellent judges of character. They do not ask what you intend. They ask when you plan to act. And they pay attention to whether you hesitate to respond, and they notice what happens if you wait too long to touch the ground.

Selaron

Selaron sits on the coast like a held breath.

It is not the largest city in the Saskan Lands, but it is the one everyone passes through eventually. Once a year, during the Selaron Market Fair, the city swells beyond recognition. Tents fill the approaches, their canvas roofs dyed in colors that are outlawed in some provinces and celebrated in others. Ships crowd the harbor so tightly you can walk from deck to deck without touching water, their banners flying signals that mean different things depending on who is reading them. At the Selaron Fair, all of Saskantimon mingles under the watchful eye of the Mother of Fires and her closest allies.

Nothing about the Fair is casual.

Weights and measures are inspected daily by a rotating panel of

overseers, two from Selaron, one from Byenung, one elected at the end of the previous Fair by the visiting merchants themselves. Coins are tested for purity at stations marked by yellow flags. Clipped coins are punished publicly: the offender's hand placed on a wooden block, a cleaver brought down cleanly, no ceremony, no second chances. The screaming lasts a few minutes. The miscreant is expelled after getting sewn up. The lesson lasts a lifetime. Prices are posted in ledgers maintained jointly by Selaron authorities and Byenung auditors, revised as supply shifts, and posted again. Lodging is regulated not just for cost, but for comfort too. Everything is just right. There are fire inspections, vermin control, and penalties for proprietors who try to cram too many bodies into too small a space.

The logic is impeccable. Merchants who feel safe make better deals. Deals made in Selaron echo for the rest of the year far beyond the Outer Lands. And every single one of them is recorded. Everything is above-board. There are no secret deals at the Selaron Fair.

Music matters too. New songs debut at the Fair because Selaron is the place where novelty can be heard, judged, absorbed and discussed before it destabilizes smaller communities. Three years ago, a song called "The Maker's Lament" was performed for the first time in the central plaza. The crowd listened in absolute silence. Two thousand people held their breath while a young woman with a voice like polished bronze sang about the Ilyushan, about their pain, about creatures who were once hum, but now are neither hum nor sint nor mixt, just a form of living pain. When she finished, no one applauded. They simply stood. Then the arguments began, spreading outward through the fairgrounds like ripples from a stone dropped in still water. The idea was outrageous. That the beasts of Ilyushan were acting out of suffering. And yet. It explained so many things.

Those arguments are still running, threading their way now through Night Hall debates and Mobali commune assemblies and Nylander councils and certain Tables of the Empafarasi and adding to dining hall chatter across the Lands.

Selaron does not rule Mobalbesq. And certainly not all the Saskan

Lands. Selaron curates newness and then sends new signals rippling around the Ring Road.

The Sharp Edge

Where Selaron is controlled and foundational, Morilly town is sharp and correctional.

The town sits inland, far enough from the coast that the air does not taste of salt but still carries the memory of it. Deals made here are done fast, rough, and occasionally bloody. This is where things that cannot pass through Selaron still find buyers. This is where most deals are made in secret and no records are kept. This is where unbreakable contracts are renegotiated and unfinished business is put to bed. Fire cult envoys meet Rider factors in taverns with no names painted on their doors. Fatunik volunteers, both the old style and the new, arrange supplies without anyone asking about their provenance or their purpose. Nylander guards pass through in pairs, eyes open, hands loose, saying little, seeing much. Romperi make a killing; it is like their high holiday celebrated in a foreign port.

Gambling dens operate openly. Not the genteel card games of Qurol and Bored but bare-knuckle wagering on dice carved from bone, on knife-throwing contests where the target stands still and trusts the thrower's aim, on races run by children who know every alley and rooftop. Mercenary lodgings cluster near the east gate. Narrow buildings have reinforced doors and second-floor windows that open onto nothing, designed so an occupant can drop into the street and be gone before pursuers reach the stairs.

Justice in Morilly is provisional and enforced by whoever can hold the mandate this season. Sometimes it is local council elders. Sometimes hired enforcers. Sometimes no one at all, and disputes are simply settled the old way, with witnesses to confirm what happened and healers standing by in case one or both parties survive.

Morilly is Selaron's dark twin. It survives because it knows exactly what it is. It does not pretend to be just. It promises to be clear. If you shake hands on a deal here, you honor it or you leave town. If you draw a weapon, you use it. Brandishing gets you killed by someone who will not wait to see if you are serious. The rules are simple. The consequences are immediate. Merchants who cannot navigate Selaron's regulations thrive here. So do people running from things they will not name.

Once they see the place, it comes as no surprise to first-time visitors that the fire cults began in the vicinity to Morilly. The largest fire temple in the province is located on a hill only a twenty-minute hike from the town.

Grounded Agriculture

The absence of flying creatures defines daily life in Mobalbesq, as it does throughout Saskantimon's agricultural zones.

Fields are pollinated by hand. Rows of workers move through the crops at dawn when the flowers are open and the air is still. Brushes pass from plant to plant, pollen dust collecting on fingertips and sleeves, the work repetitive enough to make your shoulders ache by midday. It is labor-intensive, exhausting, and prone to failure if the weather makes a sudden turn. A late frost kills the flowers. An early rain washes the pollen away. Too much wind scatters it uselessly.

In Mobalbesq, the backbreaking work carries the extra anxiety imposed by province's propensity for strange weather patterns and the necessity of slash-and-burn to renew the soil. All that effort, knowing it will never be enough, makes the Mobali a steely-eyed folk.

Fire rituals mark the start and end of these cycles, not as superstition but as coordination. When the the Marnosh Torvakar burn their field, every commune within sight knows that pollination season is ending and planting season begins in three weeks, so adjust your schedules

accordingly. The smoke is a signal before it is a prayer.

Crop failures are common. When they happen, blame is apportioned carefully. Often it falls on the weather. Sometimes on a commune that chose to burn too late or too early. Sometimes on no one at all, which is the hardest outcome to accept because it means the problem was larger than any mistake or misfortune. And larger problems mean solutions that no one has found yet.

This is why Mobalbesq tolerates no illusions about abundance. If granaries are not shared, they are burned. Hoarding is treated as theft from the future, a crime akin to murder. During the famine of Year 1792, a wealthy commune in the southern region of the province tried to withhold grain, claiming it was "private stock for seed." His granary burned the next night. No one was arrested. No one needed to be. The ashes were worked into the fields the following spring while the field workers sang a new song celebrating the bounty of fresh fertilizer.

The Moballeq Compound

Then there is THE Commune.

The Moballeq Compound sprawls across land that once fed half the Saskan Lands. Its walls are old, rebuilt many times, patched with whatever materials were available during each repair: stone, timber, brick, sheets of hammered metal salvaged from some long-forgotten project. Inside its gates are granaries large enough to buffer famine across multiple provinces, shipyards that produce vessels faster than any other port in the Saskan Lands, and administrative halls that can host assemblies numbering in the thousands.

It began not as worker-managed commune. Far from it. The latifundia, the plantation, was ruled openly by the Moballeq clan and it claimed jurisdiction over most of the Mobali lands, not only its own fields. For more than a millennia, the Moballeq extracted labor,

enforced order, and decided who ate during bad years. Though it was oppressive, its feudal system making the Riders look like a democracy, the Moballeq were also the third powerful force capable of maintaining the integrity of the Saskan Lands. While the Riders protected the mountains and the Front Tagabant fought endless battles against Wesshewen barbarians across the vast plains of the north, only the Moballeq had sufficient resources and know-how to contain and defeat the Ilyushan, over and over again, when the monstrous forms came churning across the Krbsh Sea. When that system collapsed, and it did collapse, quite suddenly and unexpectedly, with nothing to replace it, when Xavi Moballeq simply walked away from it, nobody knew what to expect.

The Moballeq domain collapsed in on itself. The commune system is what emerged from that collapse, gathering up the remnants of the most draconian and the most hard-hitting regional power in the Lands, and stitching together a new way of doing things that attempted to redress the wrongs of the past.

Then, just a little over 250 years ago, not long after the Great Conflagration that ended the Eelani-Fatunik War, she appeared and claimed control of the compound. In little time, the Compound reorganized itself into the biggest commune of all, embracing and encouraging the avalanche of collectivizations and improvisations that had sprung up in the wake of Xavi Moballeq's abdication a few hundred years beforehand. Officially, the Moballeq Compound now operates like any other Commune. Assemblies are held. Decisions are debated. Leadership rotates.

And yet. Its sheer size, and its outsized leadership, while nothing at all like the old days, places the Moballeqs -- the name stuck, even if the dynasty had vanished -- once again in the forefront of what it means to be Mobali.

As before the fall of the House Moballeq, when famine spreads, its granaries open first and widest and feed the most mouths. When fleets must be assembled to protect the Lands, its docks are the only one capable of meeting the challenge. And now, when the Selaron Fair

must function flawlessly or an entire year's trade across all the Lands might unravel, it is the Moballeq crew who organize, schedule, and absorb the risk, not for their own profit as in the old days, but to the clear benefit of the entire province and well beyond. In this way, the new leadership of the compound may have an even greater reach than the old lords did. Other communes grumble, argue, accuse. Other regions look towards Selaron and Moballeq with fear, admiration, wonder. They all accept her help. And recognize her leadership.

At the heart of it stands Monmar Massachawa.

She does not rule in the old sense. She is nothing like the Moballeq were. She issues few orders, attends assemblies irregularly, refuses most delegations without explanation. And yet her influence is felt everywhere. Not only in the way she invigorated and renewed the fire cults across Mobalbesq, but also in the improved quality of Moballeq shipbuilding, in the timing and quality of their grain releases, in the way fire singers across Mobalbesq have quietly begun teaching engineering principles alongside the old doctrines, in the way that Mobali engineers, as she calls them, now rival Byenung scholars in the calibre of formal Arguments presented to the Elders of Juuj.

When Monmar arrived over two centuries ago, the Mobali fire cults were marginal offshoots of Fatunik sun worship. She has never claimed any kind of divinity. She simply took responsibility. Under her guidance, the cults transformed. Ritual became rehearsal. Faith became a framework for survival. Thousands followed her, not because she promised salvation, but because they sensed that she was showing them how to survive what was coming, what is still coming, piling up on the horizon like storm clouds that refuse to break.

The New Fatunik Authority in Beshquahoek called her a heretic, then a demon. They never expected her to take things so far. Neither, for that matter, did those who sent her to this place contain a problem, only to discover too late that she had decided containment was not enough.

She lives in the former Moballeq Compound, surrounded by people

who love and admire her, yet profoundly alone. Her closest companion is Avron Gurk. He is a storyteller, a traveller like her, and also like Monmar he does not fit cleanly into any category. He deflects visitors, reframes questions, and absorbs the attention that Monmar has no patience for. No one is quite sure what he is but everyone understands that he is trusted, which in Mobalbesq province is the only credential that really matters.

Together, they are preparing for something that cannot be negotiated away.

In the small eastern courtyard of the Moballeq Commune, a fire singer is teaching broodkins how to build a kiln. Not a ritual kiln, a working one, fired hot enough to make bricks that will last. The kids are young at seven, maybe eight years old, but they listen with the seriousness of people who understand that survival is not guaranteed. Smoke rises into a sky that has not rained in six weeks. Somewhere to the south, near the boundary line of the commune a corn field is burning on schedule. And in a room overlooking the harbor, Monmar stands at a window, watching a ship arriving from a land that should not exist according to the maps most people still believe in. She does not smile. She simply makes a note in a ledger that no one else is allowed to read, and begins to plan for a future that has already started arriving.

The Ny Lands

The drum speaks before the voice does.

A traveler on the eastern road that runs between the central range and the desert hears it first as vibration felt through boot soles, through the bones of the feet, before the ears register rhythm. One beat. Pause. Three beats. Pause. Two. The pattern repeats. A Nylander

scout half a mile away relaxes fractionally, shifts her stance, and signals to her partner without turning her head. The message is simple: Caravan approaching. Contracted. Let them pass.

The caravan appears ten minutes later, dust rising behind twenty wagons, guards walking in formation that looks loose until you notice how their eyes track the ridge line and how no one's back is ever fully turned to open ground. They do not wave at the scouts. The scouts do not acknowledge them. The contract was signed three months ago in Morilly. Everything else is just movement.

This is how the Ny Lands work. Not through declarations or written law, but through patterns recognized, obligations honored, and the understanding that motion is survival and stillness is a choice you make when you can afford it.

A Country Without Stillness

The central range, called the Spine of Rashkel, divides its eastern and western regions. To the east, 100 kilometers of seashore melts into nearly twice as much frontage along the along the Mornon Marshes, a brackish expanse nearly as large as the Great Lake of Bye. Between the shore and the mountain lowlands stretches the semi-arid Nakarim Barrens, an high open plateau broken by ridges of exposed stone that look like the bones of something ancient pushing through skin. Wind never quite dies here.

Camps in the eastern Ny Lands are built to be dismantled. Tents are staked with iron driven deep but tied with knots designed for quick release. Fire pits are lined with stones that can be scattered in minutes. Storage is arranged so the heaviest items sit on sledges already. With the exception of small ports and fishing villages along the shore, all settlements are provisional, as if ready to pick themselves up and leave if the ground proves untrustworthy.

West of the Spine runs the Ilvarin, the river that joins Arq to the south to the Ny Lands and, continuing its rather odd northern course, to the Runes of Bye, where it feeds into the Great Lake. Along the river, the Ilvarin Ground, with its regular flooding, provides the bulk

of food grown for consumption by the Ny folk. And in the rolling plains to the west, between the Ilvarin Ground and the town of Wildwind on the shores of the Bay of Bar, the Vashkren Plains are host to a never-ending nomadic cycle.

Settlements in the Ground and on the Plains are not as ephemeral as those east of the central range, but even a place like Torven Hold, a sizable camp, will exist on summer maps and then vanish from winter ones. Not so much because it moves, but because when the wind turns cold and comes down off the high ridges with enough force to strip skin, or when the ground has become exhausted, or when the game needs to be left to recover, then the people of Torven Hold pack everything essential and relocate twenty miles west to a valley that offers shelter, or trek to the next stop on their centuries-old rotation. They have done this for generations. Most of the buildings they leave behind do not decay because they were built to be empty half the year, or longer. Stone foundations, leather roofs that can be rolled and stored, doors that bar from the outside.

Nylander society is organized around kin-groups and contracts, not territory. Authority is portable, carried in the memory of who owes what to whom and who has proven reliable when the contract was tested. Reputation is cumulative. A young guard earns standing by completing contracts without incident. An elder loses it by failing once at a critical moment. There are no appeals, no second interpretations. You did what you said you would do, or you did not.

This makes the Nylanders difficult to conquer and harder to administrate. There is nothing to seize that will stay seized. Occupy a town and they are already gone, reformed around a new camp center you have not found yet, still honoring contracts with merchants who know better than to ask where the meetings now take place.

The Nylanders Free Trade Association

The name is a joke. Like most Nylander jokes, it tells the truth faster than politeness would allow.

The FTA protects free trade by making it expensive to interfere

with. Caravans crossing the Outer Lands or even beyond can, if they wish, hire FTA protection. The price is clear, posted in Morilly and Selaron and Wildwind and updated seasonally. The terms are blunt. Payment guarantees safe passage against raiders, bandits, and the more ideologically motivated threats that drift out of the Kahila forests and the Arq badlands.

The Arql Tidejacks are the most predictable of these threats, which makes them no less dangerous. Amphibious, opportunistic, and indifferent to casualties including their own, they strike where roads narrow and river crossings slow wagons to a crawl. A Tidejack raid sounds like this... First, silence where there should be bird calls. Then a wet slithering sound, dozens of bodies moving through shallow water. Then shouting in a language that is mostly hum but bent around vowels no hum throat should manage. Then screaming, if you were not ready.

FTA guards are ready. They know the crossing points, the seasonal patterns, the specific bands and their tactics. An FTA mercenary named Tarql'ev has been running the routes along the Marshes for twelve turns, mostly protecting caravans going to and from Morilly. He can identify which Tidejack clan is operating by the pattern of their war-cries and adjust his formation accordingly. When a raid comes, the response is immediate and overwhelming. Crossbows fire in volleys tight enough that the sound is a single crack rather than a scatter. Pikes come down in unison. Bodies hit the water and do not rise. The survivors retreat. The caravan continues. TareTarql'evv makes a note in a log that will be compiled with others at season's end, tracking movements and numbers so next year's contracts can be priced accurately.

Romperi from the Kahila Forest present a different problem. Often ideologically driven, highly mobile, and willing to die for their cause in ways that make negotiation impossible, they prefer targets that make statements: grain shipments headed for Fatunik territories, Rider supply trains, anything that can be framed as collaboration with oppression. They seldom travel as far as the Ny Land; they know it would be foolish to engage with the Nylanders in their home province. But along the Ring Road and other trade routes through the

Outer Land, the Settan Lands, and in the Dominion, they are a constant menace.

FTA contracts against them are priced higher, not because they are harder to fight but because the aftermath is always complicated. A dead Tidejack is a dead Tidejack. A dead romperi becomes a Kahila martyr, and martyrs generate songs, and songs generate more romperi. Nylanders do not judge motives. They assess risk and price accordingly. There are those who say romperi activity on the Ring Road is good for FTA business. Nylanders not known to comment on such malicious gossip.

What You Get for the Price

FTA escorts are not subtle. They travel light, carry weapons openly, and set up camp where they can see in all directions. An FTA night camp establishes lines of fire in a triangle pattern, guards rotate in pairs every two hours, and mounts are picketed in the center where theft requires crossing open ground under watch. No singing and no drinking before the last watch reports clear. Conversations happen in murmurs that do not carry past the firelight.

They also do not break contract. Ever.

A merchant from Terpinol once tried to renegotiate terms mid-journey, claiming the price was unfair given how quiet the roads had been. The FTA guard captain, a woman named Sielle whose left ear was missing from an incident she never discussed, listened politely, then explained that quiet roads were the result of FTA presence, not its absence, and that if the merchant felt safe enough to complain he was welcome to proceed alone from this point forward, but no payments would be refunded. The merchant declined. He paid the remaining fee in full at journey's end and hired them again the next season without attempting negotiation.

When a caravan is attacked, the response is decisive. Nylanders favor overwhelming force followed by rapid withdrawal. They are not

interested in holding ground, pursuing fleers into difficult terrain, or extracting revenge beyond what the contract requires. A Tidejack band that loses half its number in an ambush thwarted by the FTA learns its lesson or it dies out. A romperi cell that strikes an FTA-protected caravan discovers that ideology offers poor protection against professionally-targeted violence.

Merchants who complain about the cost are invited to try the route without protection. Few do. Fewer repeat the experiment.

Wildwind, the Original Version

For most of the year, Wildwind town, the only permanent settlement in the Ny Lands, is a practical place. It sits on open ground near a reliable spring and near the Baybar coast. Wind-scoured and empty except for a few permanent structures that serve as winter shelter for anyone who needs them, a board where announcements and prices are posted and some watchers, getting on in turns, who keep an eye on the place all four seasons.

Then, once every turn, the Festival comes. THE Wildwind Festival. THE ruk'taan.

Caravans arrive days early, staking positions that were negotiated the previous year or decades ago, marked with stones that have been moved and replaced so many times they are smooth as pottery. Many of the Mobali communes send delegates. Some are official, some self-appointed, all expected to report back accurately. Fire singers from Mobalbesq bring their drums, large ones that take two people to carry and small ones worn on straps that leave bruises across the ribs after a full day's playing. Byenung regularly sends large numbers of observers who try to pretend they are not fascinated by everything they see.

And folks of all types come from all over. It's the biggest party in the Saskan Lands, bar none. The Nylanders host it, and for three days the entire region exhales at once.

The Wildwind Festival is not a big annual market, neither official nor under wraps. Those roles are handled by Selaron and Morilly. It is

not a council. In the region of the Outer Lands, that burden falls to the Night Hall in Byenung and possibly, in a new way, to Brokily in Kahilabequa as well.

No, Wildwind is something older and much less tidy. It is a reaffirmation that people who disagree profoundly can still share space without killing one another. Yes, contracts are renewed here, for sure, especially those between the Nylander tribes. Old grudges are acknowledged and occasionally set aside. New alliances are made and tested in public where everyone can see the terms being offered and accepted, who is joining together with whom for the next turn.

And there is feasting. And a dance unlike any other.

Food is abundant because every kin-group brings their best and no one wants to be shamed by poor hospitality. This applies to the foreigners as well as to the Nylanders. A Mobalbesq commune might arrive with smoked fish packed in salt, dried fruit that has been soaked in honey, bread baked that morning and still warm in its wrappings. A Runik delegation brings cheese aged in caverns near the Great Lake, beer brewed to a recipe they will not share, preserved vegetables pickled in brine so sharp it makes your eyes water. Nylander families contribute every type of game and fish venison, rabbit, sharks roasted whole with herbs stuffed in the cavity. The smell alone draws people from across the gathering. It rises from charred meat, wood smoke, bread, spices that have traveled from ports you cannot find on any official map.

In a normal turn, a few visitors even come from as far away as the Komikols and Aranzen. All are welcomed, even folks from the Dominion, should they choose to make the trip.

And at the center of it all is the sound.

Ruk'taan

The ruk'taan begins quietly.

One drum. A slow beat, steady as a heartbeat, felt more than heard at first. Feet stomp in patterns that seem simple until you try to follow them. The rhythm shifts subtly every fourth beat, then every third,

then returns to the original pattern just as you think you understand it. Hands clap, off-rhythm at first, then snapping into alignment so suddenly it sounds like a single crack of thunder. Voices join in not by singing, not by chanting, but by breathing together in controlled bursts that pulse with the drum.

The tempo rises. The ground seems to respond, dust lifting in small clouds around the dancers' feet.

This is not entertainment, though it amuses visitors who do not yet understand what they are watching. The ruk'taan is how Nylanders negotiate without words. It is how kin-groups test one another's resolve, signal boundaries, offer alliances or end them. During inter-tribal encounters, the patterns carry meaning that must be earned through years of participation. A particular stomp means: I acknowledge your claim but reserve judgment. A shift in hand-clapping rhythm means: I dispute this and will explain why later. A sudden silence in the drums means: Stop. Something is wrong.

There are numerous exchanges of partnerships going on between the Nylands groups throughout the ruk'taan. What might appear to outsiders as a kind of dance where folks switch places in a chaotic pattern is much more than that. Part of the secret to the coherence of the Ny Land tribes is trading personnel. Children are sent to live with a different tribe. Something resembling temporary marriages and partnerships are formed, broken apart and reformed. Elders are honored by being asked to travel with a different band for a time.

Outsiders often miss these cues and the meaning of these movements entirely. A Fatunik volunteer from the Runes of Bye once applauded enthusiastically during a pause that signaled a serious disagreement over water rights was being resolved. The ruk'taan stopped. Every Nylander present turned to look at him. He never made that mistake again.

At Wildwind, the ruk'taan culminates in a thunderous convergence that can be felt through to the bone. This is the point at which all of the agreements, the changes, the new patterns for the next turn have been agreed and it is time to celebrate and affirm and feel the power that the transformations will bring. People who may have never agreed on anything else, who may have difficulty understanding each

others' dialect, find themselves moving together, hundreds of feet striking the earth in unison, hands clapping patterns so complex they sound like language, voices rising in a sound that is neither music nor speech but something older than both.

For a time beyond reckoning, unity is not only possible; it is visceral. This is the point in the ruk'taan when pairings are sometimes consummated for the first time, in the midst of the dance. Spinning. Carrying. Jumping. No words are spoken during the culmination of the ruk'taan. Thousands are participating. It is a a thunderous, timeless, ecstatic moment that goes on for twenty or thirty minutes.

Then all at once the drums stop. Everyone discovers who they are again, remembers which contracts they will honor and which they can drop, which kin-groups they are bound to now, and which ones they might need to watch more carefully.

The silence immediately after the ruk'taan is always longer than it seems it should be.

On the Edge of Motion

Life in the Ny Lands is spare, loud only when it must be, and when it must be loud it is very loud. Nylanders are unforgiving of pretense.

Children learn early how to read wind direction, body language, and the particular quality of silence that means danger is approaching. Elders are respected for judgment, not age. A forty-year-old with good instincts commands more authority than a seventy-year-old who has made too many poor calls. Stories are told around fires, but only after the perimeter is checked, mounts secured, and watches assigned.

Sints are common here in roughly the same proportions as elsewhere in the Outer Lands. Rabbit-sints often handle logistics, their quick hands and excellent memories making them invaluable for tracking complex contract terms. Others, those who are heavier-bodied, long-limbed, built for endurance, fit easily into Nylander mobility culture. What matters is not form but follow-through. Can you keep pace? Can you read the signs? Can you hold a position when the contract requires you to?

Jaxen tend to fail quickly here. They have trouble keeping up. Their limited emotional range and inability to improvise under pressure make them liabilities in a culture where a particular quality of silence can mean "act now" or "hold position" or "something is wrong and we do not yet know what." Most often they are simply left behind when the nomadic shift occurs. Nylanders rarely explain this. Explanation invites debate and debate slows movement.

When potentially undesirable strangers arrive at the Festival, often the drumming stops and everyone stares. Nylanders notice a change in the air before such soldiers or miscreants appeared. This kind of stillness is not peaceful. There is a tension in the way mounts shift in their pickets and the Nylander guards move to better positions. But there is never a confrontation. Not at Wildwind. Only an acknowledgment. Some of the Ny Landers step back into shadows. Others step forward to memorize faces, making notes that will never be written down but will be remembered when contracts are renegotiated.

They do not intervene even if the Rider Arms or the Meyajo Tagabant make an arrest, or if a Komikol bear-sint roars an insult. There are no contracts governing the behavior on outsiders at Wildwind. And Nylanders do not improvise when violence is involved unless survival demands it, or unless a contract has already been made to act in this situation.

But they all remember when the drums stop. When the time comes to move again, and it always again in just a few minutes, the drums start up again and the ruk'taan has changed its pattern, and people who understand its language will know exactly what is being said.

On a ridge above the old caravan road, a Nylander guard watches the horizon. The wind carries dust from the south, which means a caravan is coming from Arq, which means he will know in ten minutes whether they are contracted or need to be turned back. His partner sits with her back to a stone, eyes closed, listening to sounds he cannot hear. Neither speaks. There is nothing to say yet. The contract is clear. The terms are known. Everything else is just motion, and motion is what the Ny Lands do best. Constant, deliberate, and

ready to stop the moment stopping serves a purpose.